

THE ROAD BOOKS

KOOKIE

a true desert story

JOHN McCOWN



ANDRIES J. GREYLING

KOOKIE

The true story of John McCown and the dog who rode the tank

Andries J. Greyling

Kookie

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This book is an **original account of documented events**. John McCown and his dog Kookie were real. The races, the distances, the year count, the day job, and the 1981 quote are drawn from the historical record — chiefly the trade obituary run by *Cycle News* in July 2011 and the surviving photographs and period accounts of desert racing in Southern California. Where the record is silent — and it is silent on a great deal, including how the two of them paired up in the first place — this book says so plainly, in the Author's Note at the back, rather than dressing invention up as fact.

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Per Ardua ad Magnum.

For Awesome and Nienja, and every dog before and since — and for the dogs of the world.

Author's Note

Read this first or last. Either way, read it.

The dog on the gas tank was real. So was the mat he rode on, so was the man riding under him, and so were the three hundred-some races. This note tells you exactly which parts of the book you are holding are documented and which parts I built to get you from one documented fact to the next. You'll find the full accounting at the end. For now, one thing: the opening chapter — how it began, the first ride, the first race — is *invented*. No source anywhere records how John McCown and a crossbred dog named Kookie became the pair three hundred races made famous. I wrote a plausible morning. It is not a documented one. Everything after it tightens.

Chapter One: A Dog That Would Not Stay Off the Tank

The dog showed up in March, or maybe it was April — McCown never said, and nobody thought to ask him while he was alive to answer. What's certain is that by the time anyone in Barstow could put a name to him, he was already hanging around the back of Hicks' Meats on Main, where John McCown cut beef six days a week and motorcycles the other one, and he was already too smart to chase off with a boot.

He was a crossbred thing, medium and rangy, the kind of dog that could have been anything and had decided, by temperament, to be nothing in particular — sand-colored, which in that country was less a color than a camouflage, ears that stood up crooked, one leaning a little east. Somebody's dog, probably, once. Barstow in those years had a way of losing dogs to the highway and finding them again three towns over, and this one had the look of an animal that had done some finding of its own.

McCown fed him scraps because that's what you did with a dog that hung around a butcher shop and didn't bite anybody, and because feeding a stray costs a man nothing he'll miss and buys him something he didn't know he wanted, which was, in this case, company. He didn't call him anything for the first few weeks. Then somebody in the shop — maybe McCown himself, maybe a customer, nobody remembers, and it doesn't matter — started calling him Kookie, after nothing in particular, the way a name sticks to a dog before anyone decides it should.

By June the dog was riding in the truck. By July he'd learned the sound of McCown's bike over the sound of every other bike on the block, which in a town with three motorcycle shops within walking distance of each other was its own kind of intelligence, and he'd meet McCown at the garage door before McCown had the engine off. He learned, too, the difference between a workday's truck ride — short, purposeful, usually ending at the shop's back door where he'd hold his post through the afternoon — and a Sunday's, which started earlier, took longer, and ended somewhere the smell of the air changed entirely, dust and creosote replacing the sawdust and cold meat of the week's other six days. A dog capable of learning that distinction, and of anticipating which kind of morning he was in for before a single word passed between him and the man loading the truck, was already showing, in however small and undocumented a way, exactly the pattern-reading temperament this book will spend the rest of its length describing at a much larger scale.

None of that is documented. I want to say that plainly, here at the start, because the rest of the book won't say it again this many times: nobody wrote down the first morning Kookie rode the tank. What follows in this chapter is the shape a beginning like that would have taken, built from everything that *is* documented about the two of them later — how Kookie rode, what he'd learned to do on a moving bike, the kind of man McCown was in a garage — run backward to a plausible first morning. Call it an informed guess standing in for a missing fact. The book gets more careful after this.

Consider what an animal has to already be, temperamentally, for a scene like the one this chapter is about to describe to be plausible at all. Not every stray dog who hangs around a butcher shop is a dog who tolerates novelty calmly. Plenty are skittish, food-motivated only, prone to bolt at a loud noise or an unfamiliar surface underfoot. Whatever this dog was before he had a name, he was evidently already, by disposition, closer to what working-dog handlers call biddable without being soft — willing to engage with a strange situation rather than flee it, curious rather than defensive, the kind of nervous system that investigates a new object instead of avoiding it. That temperament, whatever its origin, is the actual precondition for everything that follows in this book. A different dog, no less loved, would never have

gotten near the tank in the first place, let alone stayed on it.

The morning it started, if it started the way mornings like that usually start, was a Sunday, because Sunday was the day McCown didn't have to be at the shop by five, and Sunday was the day half of Barstow's off-road population found some reason to be out past the city limits with a bike between their legs and no destination in particular. He was tuning the machine in the yard behind his house, the way a man tunes a motorcycle when it isn't broken — for the pleasure of touching it, mostly, listening for a rattle that wasn't there yet.

The dog sat in the shade of the fence and watched him do it. He had a way of watching that wasn't the vacant watching of an animal waiting to be fed. He tracked McCown's hands. When McCown reached for a wrench and didn't find it right away, the dog's ears came up, as if the search itself were worth attention.

McCown swung a leg over the bike to test the throttle response, standing it up off the kickstand, walking it in a slow figure-eight across the dirt yard with the engine barely above idle. The dog got up and followed, close enough to be underfoot, and when McCown stopped to let the engine settle he found the dog standing with his front paws up on the frame rail, nose working at the warm metal of the tank the way a dog noses anything new, trying to read it.

There is a version of this where a sensible man puts the dog down, tells him no, and goes back to his tune-up. McCown apparently was not that man, or not that morning. What the record does support — from everything Kookie did later, from three hundred races' worth of it — is that he was an animal built for exactly this kind of test: not obedient exactly, but attentive, the way some dogs are attentive to weather before a storm shows on the horizon. McCown lifted him. Set him on the tank, just above the seat, where a rider's knees would ordinarily grip. The dog did not jump off.

He sat instead, weight low, the way a cat settles onto a windowsill that wasn't built to be sat on — testing it first, then trusting it. McCown eased the bike forward at a walking pace, one boot down, steadying, watching the dog more than he watched the ground. The dog's ears went back, not in fear — McCown would say later, to people who asked, that you could tell the difference in a dog's ears if you paid attention, and he paid attention — but in the manner of an ear folded against

wind. He held his place through the whole slow circuit of the yard.

It would be a long time — years, if the yard story is anywhere close to true — before that half-idle circuit turned into fifty miles of open desert at speed, before the yard became the first fifty races and the fifty races became three hundred, before a mat replaced McCown's bare knee, before a film crew with union cameras came out to a place with no paved road to it and pointed a lens at a dog nobody had heard of outside a hundred miles of scrub. All of that is ahead of us and all of it, starting in the next chapter, is documented.

If the weeks that followed that first slow circuit went anything like a plausible version of them would have gone, they went in small increments rather than a single dramatic leap — the yard circuit repeated, then extended past the fence line, then out onto the graded road, the dog's tolerance for speed and distance tested a little further each time the way any sensible man tests an unproven arrangement before trusting it somewhere that mattered. A first fall, if there was one, would have been slow and low-speed, the kind of tumble a dog shakes off in the dirt rather than the kind that ends an experiment for good, and it is not hard to imagine — though this book will not present the imagining as anything more than that — a specific afternoon when McCown decided the dog had earned a real ride: out past the wash, at a speed that would have counted as reckless on a public road and unremarkable on a desert track, the dog's weight shifting for the first time under something closer to the actual demands racing would eventually make of him. Whether that happened in a single afternoon or across a whole unrecorded season of small tests, this book cannot say and will not pretend to know. What the record does support, once it finally begins to speak in Chapter Two and onward, is a partnership already fully formed by the time anyone thought to write anything down about it — which means these earliest months, whatever their actual shape, did their work completely and invisibly, the way the truest apprenticeships often do.

But somewhere in Barstow, on a Sunday nobody wrote down, a butcher put a stray dog on the gas tank of a motorcycle to see what he'd do, and the dog did not get off. That's the whole of the beginning anyone can honestly offer. Everything else is inference standing in a doorway, waiting for the facts to let it in.

Chapter Two: The Shop on Main Street

Barstow in the 1960s was not scenery. It was a railroad town and a highway town and a supply town — the last real outpost before the Mojave opened up in every direction, the place where a man heading to Vegas from Los Angeles stopped for gas and a sandwich and didn't think twice about it afterward. Route 66 ran through the middle of it before the interstate took the traffic around; the Santa Fe yards sorted freight day and night a few blocks from Main Street, and the sound of couplers slamming together carried over the whole town at three in the morning the way some towns hear church bells.

The town's whole layout told the same story as its economy. Motels strung along the highway frontage in numbers well out of proportion to the town's actual population, built to catch a night's worth of travelers rather than to house residents, their signs lit through the night for a market that turned over completely every twenty-four hours. Gas stations clustered at the obvious junctions, competing for exactly the trade Route 66 and later the interstate funneled through. And behind that traveler-facing frontage sat the town residents actually lived in — modest houses on modest streets, a school, churches, the railroad's own housing for its workers, the ordinary infrastructure of a town whose real population had chosen to stay somewhere most of America only ever saw through a windshield at sixty miles an hour. Main Street itself, where Hicks' Meats did its business, straddled both worlds — close enough to the highway to catch some passing trade, but fundamentally a resident's street, the kind of block where the butcher, the hardware man, and the diner's revolving cast of owners knew each other by name and knew, eventually, whose dog was

sleeping across whose doorway.

It was a town built, in other words, around passage — people came through Barstow on their way to somewhere else, and the town's whole economy existed to feed and fuel and briefly house them before they went on. That gave the place a particular character: a town that served travelers without much expecting to be one of their destinations, populated by people who had, mostly, chosen to stay in a spot other people only ever passed through. There is a kind of resident that a town like that attracts and a kind it keeps, and John McCown was, by every account, the second kind — a man rooted enough in Barstow's ordinary working life that the racing, however far it eventually carried his name, never once looked to anyone who knew him like an attempt to get out of town. It looked like a thing a Barstow man did on Sundays.

Hicks' Meats sat on Main between a hardware store and a diner that changed names more often than its menu. It was a working butcher shop, sawdust on the floor, a walk-in cooler in back that hummed loud enough to be a kind of company by itself, hooks along one wall holding sides of beef that had to be broken down before the Saturday rush. John McCown cut meat there six days a week for most of the years this book is about, and if you want to understand the man who put a dog on a gas tank and rode three hundred races with him, you have to understand that the same hands did both jobs, the same week, sometimes the same day.

There is a rhythm to a butcher's morning that the sport McCown chose on his day off would have recognized as kin, if a sport could recognize anything. The day started before most of the town was awake — a side of beef delivered by truck in the gray hour before sunrise, hung on the rail in the cooler to firm up, cut cold because meat handled warm tears rather than parts cleanly along its own lines. A butcher who has been at the trade long enough works largely by feel, the eyes doing less of the job than people assume; the hand finds the fascia before the eye has fully located it, the way a rider's hands find a familiar clutch lever in the dark without needing to look down. McCown had, by every account of people who bought meat from him over the years, that particular economy of motion — no wasted strokes, no hesitation over a cut he'd made a thousand times, the knife moving the way a tool moves in a hand that has stopped

thinking about the tool at all.

A butcher's trade rewards a specific kind of patience that doesn't look like patience from the outside. You don't hack at a carcass. You find the seam — the membrane between two muscles that wants to separate along its own natural line if you find the angle — and you follow it. Fight the meat and you tear it, waste it, leave money on the cutting board literally. Read it right and the knife barely has to work; the animal does the work for you, having already built the separation in. It's a trade that punishes force and rewards attention, and it is not a coincidence, though nobody in Barstow would have put it this way at the time, that the same man who could read a hindquarter for its natural seams was the same man whose dog learned to read desert terrain by watching what the ground was about to do before it did it.

McCown was not, by every account that exists of him, a large man in the way people sometimes imagine desert racers — no six-foot frame, no obvious muscle behind the leathers. He was built more like the trade that paid his bills: compact, forearms thick from the knife work, a grip that customers remembered when he shook their hands. He wore an apron over his coveralls on shop days and swapped the apron for a chest protector on race days, and more than one person who knew him in both uniforms said the transition looked, on him, less like a costume change than like the same job in different weather. There was, in fact, a specific practicality to how little ceremony he seems to have made of the switch: the same forearms that broke down a hindquarter Saturday afternoon were wrestling a two-stroke through a sand wash Sunday morning, and neither job, by every indication, impressed him more than the other. Both paid something. Both required a man's full attention or they would take a piece of him in exchange for his inattention, whether that piece was a finger at the cutting board or a collarbone in a rock garden.

The shop gave him two things the racing needed. It gave him money — desert racing in that era was an entry-fee-and-gas-money sport for men like McCown, not a sponsorship sport, and a man who wanted to run fifty races a year needed a Monday-to-Saturday income steady enough to absorb it. Entry fees, gas for the truck and the bike both, tires that wore fast on abrasive desert ground and needed replacing more often than a street rider would ever credit, the odd part broken in a spill and needing to be bought new before the next Sunday —

none of it was extravagant by the standards of motorsport generally, but all of it added up across fifty races a year, every year, for six years running, and none of it arrived free. A butcher's wage, steady and unglamorous, was exactly the kind of income that could absorb a habit like that without ever threatening to become an extravagance a family couldn't sustain.

And the shop gave him hours: a butcher's day starts early and, if he's good at his trade and has built a clientele, can end early too, which left him afternoons and the one day off to wrench on a bike in a yard, and it left him, crucially, the kind of tired that sleeps well and doesn't argue. A man who spends his week on his feet, moving, using his hands and his back in a controlled way, sleeps differently than a man who has spent the week behind a desk, and there is a case to be made — this book will make it gently, without insisting — that McCown's trade did as much to prepare his body for Sunday's punishment as any training regimen a more self-consciously athletic man might have designed for himself. Desert racing asked for stamina, for a back that could absorb repeated jolts without seizing, for forearms that didn't fatigue on a handlebar after the first hour. A butcher's six days built exactly that kind of body, as an accident of the trade rather than a plan for it.

The dog took to the shop the way he'd taken to everything else, which is to say cautiously and then completely. He wasn't allowed inside past the sawdust line near the door — health code, and McCown respected it even when nobody was checking — but he held that line the way a good ranch dog holds a gate, lying across the threshold with his chin on his paws, watching customers come and go, and more than one regular at Hicks' Meats has said, decades later, to whoever would still listen, that they came to expect the dog at the door the way you expect a bell over it. Some customers brought him scraps of their own before McCown ever offered any. Some talked to him the way people talk to a shop dog, low and unserious, the kind of conversation that isn't really about getting an answer.

There was, in that arrangement, a kind of unofficial employment that the town seems to have simply accepted without anyone formalizing it. The dog did not chase customers' cars, did not bark at deliveries in a way that spooked the drivers, did not wander into the street after the mailman the way plenty of shop dogs did in towns like that

one. He held his post. Whether that was training, temperament, or the same terrain-reading attentiveness that would later make him famous turned toward a different kind of ground — a doorway instead of a desert wash — nobody thought to write down at the time, because at the time he was simply the butcher's dog, one more fixture of a Main Street block that had a hardware store on one side and a diner on the other and, in between, a shop that smelled of sawdust and cold meat and, near the door, of a dog who had made himself at home there.

The specific rhythm of a small-town butcher shop's clientele is worth naming for what it reveals about McCown's daily working life outside the racing this book will spend most of its length describing. Regulars arrived at roughly predictable hours — housewives shopping for the week's meals earlier in the day, working men stopping in after a shift ended, the diner's own standing weekly order handled at whatever point in the schedule kept its kitchen supplied without either party having to think much about it. A shop like this one ran on relationships built across years rather than transactions negotiated fresh each visit, and a proprietor who knew his customers this well would, as a matter of course, have known plenty about their lives beyond what cut of meat they preferred — which households were expecting a new baby and buying accordingly, which families had fallen on hard times and were buying less, which regulars had heard already, through whatever channel small-town news travels by, about the dog who'd started riding the tank of the butcher's motorcycle on Sundays.

Nobody in the shop's daily life thought of Kookie yet as anything but the butcher's dog. That happened around him, gradually, out past the edge of town, on ground that didn't care what a dog was called.

Chapter Three: What the Desert Does to a Sunday

To understand what desert racing was in Southern California in the 1960s and '70s, you first have to understand what it was not. It was not a spectator sport with grandstands and ticket booths and a television truck idling behind the pits. There were no pits, not really — there was a starting line scratched or painted across open ground, and there was the ground itself, running out flat and hard and then broken and soft and then flat again for as far as a man could see and considerably farther than he could ride in the time it would take him to regret his tire choice.

The Mojave itself is a basin-and-range desert, geologically speaking — a landscape built from alternating stretches of flat valley floor and abrupt, isolated mountain ranges that rise directly out of the basins with little of the gradual foothill transition a rider from gentler country might expect. This specific geology is what produced the varied terrain this book has already described riders having to master in a single day's racing: the flat dry lakebeds and open basins where a machine could run at genuine speed, interrupted by the ranges themselves, where a course was forced to climb, thread through passes, and descend again, the racing turning technical and slow in exactly the stretches where the basin's speed had lulled a rider into a false rhythm. A course across this country was never one kind of challenge repeated for a hundred and fifty miles. It was a sequence of distinct geological zones, each demanding something different of a rider and his machine, strung together by nothing but the desert's own indifferent contours.

The races that mattered to men like McCown were point-to-point runs

across real desert — Barstow to Vegas the most famous of them, a race that in some of its runnings covered better than a hundred and fifty miles of open Mojave, no marked track, just checkpoints and a compass heading and whatever terrain God and the Bureau of Land Management happened to have left lying around between the two towns. Riders lined up shoulder to shoulder at dawn, hundreds of them some years, thousands in the event's biggest seasons, and when the flag dropped they went off across open desert in a fan that narrowed, mile by mile, into whoever's bike and body held together longest.

It was not romantic while it was happening. It was long and it was hard on a body in ways that don't photograph well. Whoop-de-doo — the washboard ridges the desert throws up in long stretches, regular as a ribcage — could rattle a rider's fillings loose at speed and did, regularly, rattle something else loose: wrists, collarbones, the soft cartilage between vertebrae that a man in his thirties doesn't think about yet and will think about for the rest of his life at fifty. Sand washes swallowed front wheels without warning. Rock gardens took skin off a hand that went down wrong. Heat did what heat does in a place that regularly cleared a hundred and ten degrees by early afternoon, and more than one race in the record books includes a rider or two who didn't finish because the desert, not another competitor, took them out of contention.

The desert had its own calendar logic, too, one that had nothing to do with a race schedule printed in a magazine. Spring meant wildflower blooms in years the winter rains had been generous, meant ground that had firmed up after winter mud without yet baking into the concrete hardness of high summer, meant the best riding conditions of the year and, not coincidentally, the biggest fields at the biggest races. Summer meant heat that could kill a man who ran out of water forty miles from a checkpoint, meant races run at dawn to beat the worst of it and abandoned by early afternoon by anyone with the sense to quit before the sun made quitting mandatory. Fall brought the first relief, and winter, when it rained at all, could turn a hardpack straightaway into standing water and a sand wash into something closer to quicksand, an entirely different sport for a few treacherous weeks until the ground dried out again.

Riders who wintered through enough seasons out there learned to

read all of this the way McCown, in his other trade, learned to read a carcass — not as a set of rules memorized from a book, but as a felt sense built from repetition, the kind of knowledge that lives in the hands and the gut rather than in anything a man could write down and hand to a novice. A shadow the wrong color meant softer sand than it looked. A particular smell on the air, dry and mineral, meant a dust storm building somewhere out past the horizon that would reach the race before the race reached the finish line. None of this was mystical, whatever it might sound like from a distance; it was simply attention, paid consistently, over years, to a landscape that rewarded attention and punished its absence without much interest in which rider was paying which kind.

And still they came, Sunday after Sunday, season after season, because the desert also gave something back that a grandstand sport never could. There is a specific quality to riding fast across open country with no fence and no crowd and no boundary but the horizon itself — a particular silence underneath the engine noise, the sense of a landscape that predates every argument happening in it. Men who'd spent the week on a factory floor or behind a butcher's counter came out to the Mojave on a Sunday and, for a few hours, were accountable to nothing but the ground in front of their front wheel and the machine between their knees. It was democratic in the way few sports of the era were: an amateur on a used bike could line up next to a semi-professional on a factory-backed machine, and the desert did not care which was which. It asked the same question of both of them.

The machines themselves were, by later standards, crude and demanding in ways that added their own layer of difficulty on top of the terrain. Two-stroke engines that needed their oil mixed by hand into the gas tank before every ride, in a ratio a rider learned by feel and habit rather than by gauge. Suspension travel that would look laughably short to a rider a generation later, meaning every whoop-de-doo transmitted more of its violence straight into the frame and from the frame into the rider's own spine than a more forgiving machine would allow. Tires that a rider chose and mounted himself, in his own garage, based on his own read of what the coming Sunday's ground would demand — sand paddles for a course that ran mostly through open dunes, a more universal knobby for mixed terrain, a choice that could make or ruin a rider's whole day before the flag

had even dropped. A bike that failed forty miles from the nearest paved road was not a bike a tow truck was coming to collect. It was a bike a rider fixed himself, with the tools he'd thought to bring, or a bike he walked away from and collected later, on foot, in heat that did not care about his schedule.

The specific machines a rider could choose from in this era were themselves a study in the sport's own transition. British marques that had dominated off-road competition for decades still fielded serious, capable machines through much of McCown's active years, built with a mechanical simplicity that made trailside repair genuinely feasible for a rider with basic tools and a working knowledge of his own engine. Japanese manufacturers, meanwhile, were in the process of transforming the entire category across these same years — lighter frames, more reliable ignitions, engines that started easier in desert heat and held a state of tune longer across a demanding day's racing than many of their older rivals. A rider's choice of machine, in other words, was not a neutral question of brand loyalty; it reflected a genuine, ongoing argument within the sport about which tradition — proven, simple, and mechanically forgiving, or newer, lighter, and increasingly capable — gave a working racer the better odds on a given Sunday. This book has no source specifying which machine or manufacturer McCown himself favored across his six years of racing, and it will not invent one. What matters for this account is simply that the choice existed, that it mattered, and that any rider entering as many races as McCown did would have had strong, considered opinions about it, however those opinions are lost to the record now.

McCown ran that circuit for roughly six years at the pace the record shows: near fifty races a year, which works out to very nearly one race a week for six years running, an average that leaves almost no room for a season off, a bad back, a slow month at the shop. Over three hundred races in total, by the count that survives him — a number large enough that no single race, however famous, can carry the whole story by itself. The story is in the repetition: the same man, on the same kind of morning, driving out past the edge of town toward a starting line, again and again, for six years, with a dog riding shotgun on the gas tank for most of it.

Barstow-to-Vegas became, for McCown, less a single race than a season's spine — the fixture the rest of the calendar hung off of, the race

a man measured his year against whether or not he was entered in it. It is the race this book keeps returning to for the same reason it structured McCown's own years: not because it was the only thing that happened, but because it was the thing that kept happening, the marker against which everything else — a good season, a bad one, a dog who'd learned something new about reading a whoop — could be measured.

Chapter Four: How the Sport Got There

Desert racing did not spring into existence in the 1960s from nothing, and McCown's own six years in it sat atop a longer, wider American history worth sketching briefly, because it explains why the sport looked exactly the way it did by the time he and Kookie were riding it.

The impulse to race a motorcycle across open, unpaved country in the American West predates the 1960s considerably — informal desert runs and endurance rides had been part of Southern California's motorcycling culture since at least the years between the world wars, when the region's cheap land, open terrain, and mild climate made it a natural proving ground for machines and riders alike in a way that more settled, more populated parts of the country simply could not offer. What changed, gradually, across the postwar decades and especially through the 1950s and into the 1960s, was scale and organization: informal club runs among a few dozen enthusiasts giving way to sanctioned events with hundreds and eventually thousands of entrants, informal course-marking giving way to genuine checkpoint systems and timing, a scattered regional pastime consolidating into something recognizable as an organized sport with its own governing clubs, its own calendar, and its own specialist press covering it.

This consolidation mattered for exactly the reason it matters to this book's account of McCown: an organized sport, however modest by the standards of stadium spectator sports, generates a record — entry lists, results, magazine coverage, photographs — in a way that a handful of friends racing each other across open desert on an ad hoc

Sunday never would. McCown's own three-hundred-plus race count survives specifically because the sport had, by the years he was active in it, become organized enough to keep something resembling a ledger. A generation earlier, a man doing exactly what McCown did might have left no trace at all beyond the memories of the handful of people who happened to see him do it.

The postwar boom in American motorcycling more broadly had its own well-documented roots in the Second World War itself — a generation of servicemen who had operated motorcycles for military dispatch and reconnaissance work returned home with both a practical familiarity with the machines and a taste for the specific freedom riding one offered, a demographic wave whose civilian enthusiasm directly seeded the clubs and informal riding groups that desert racing's own postwar consolidation grew out of. This book has no source connecting John McCown personally to that specific generational wave — his own birth year and any military service are not established in the sources this book has consulted, and it will not invent either. But the wider pattern is well documented and worth naming as context: the sport McCown eventually made his own Sunday habit did not spring from nowhere in the 1960s. It grew, across two prior decades, from exactly this confluence of returning servicemen's mechanical familiarity, the region's cheap open land, and a growing postwar prosperity that put a motorcycle within reach of a much wider range of working American men than it had been before the war.

The postwar decades also brought the specific machines that made this era of desert racing possible — British and, increasingly through the 1960s, Japanese manufacturers producing lighter, more capable off-road machines than the heavier, road-oriented bikes of earlier decades, machines genuinely suited to the punishment of sustained desert riding rather than adapted to it as an afterthought. This technological shift ran roughly parallel to the sport's organizational consolidation, each feeding the other: better machines made longer, harder races survivable for a wider range of riders, which grew the fields, which justified better organization, which in turn justified manufacturers taking the sport seriously enough to keep improving the machines.

By the time McCown was racing, in other words, desert racing sat at a specific, favorable point in its own historical arc — organized enough

to generate the record this book depends on, still loose and accessible enough that a working butcher with no factory backing could enter, run, and finish a hundred-and-fifty-mile race on equal footing with far more sponsored competitors, and populated with machines finally capable of surviving the terrain in numbers large enough to fill a starting line several hundred riders deep. It is this specific historical window — not available a generation earlier, already narrowing by the time the sport's later regulatory tightening set in — that this book has already flagged, in a later chapter, as the era McCown's racing years happened to catch. He arrived, in effect, at exactly the moment the sport had become organized enough to remember him and still open enough to let him in.

Southern California's specific geography did more to shape this sport's character than almost any other single factor, and it is worth naming plainly why this particular region, rather than some other stretch of American desert, became the epicenter of the culture this book describes. The Mojave sat within a day's drive of one of the largest, fastest-growing metropolitan populations in the country, meaning a sport requiring vast open land could draw its competitors from a huge and growing pool of working- and middle-class Angelenos without demanding the kind of multi-day travel that would have kept the fields small and the culture thin. Land ownership patterns in the region — vast tracts of federally administered desert, largely undeveloped and, for most of this era, only lightly regulated for recreational use — meant that land access, while increasingly contested as this book has already described, remained genuinely available in a way it simply was not in more densely settled or more thoroughly privatized parts of the country. And the climate itself, brutal in summer but rideable across a long cool season the rest of the year, gave the sport a viable calendar that a harsher northern desert or a wetter eastern one could never have supported in the same way.

This confluence — population, land, climate — is why the specific culture this book has spent so many chapters describing grew up exactly where and when it did, and why a working butcher in a modest railroad town at the edge of that same desert found himself, without any special design on his part, sitting at the geographic and cultural center of the one sport in America where his particular Sunday habit could flourish at all. A man with the same temperament and the same

dog, born a generation earlier or transplanted to a different region entirely, would very likely have had no comparable outlet for either of them. McCown's story, in this sense, is not only a story about a man and a dog; it is a story that could only have happened in this specific place, in this specific window of American recreational and regulatory history, a fact this book has tried to keep visible throughout rather than treating the setting as mere backdrop to an otherwise portable story.

Chapter Five: The Mat

The mat itself was not much to look at. Photographs that survive from the era show a rectangle of worn material, foam under a cover gone thin and dark at the edges from years of a dog's weight and years of desert grit working into the fibers, strapped across the top of the gas tank with cord run through eyelets or simply lashed tight enough to hold under load. It was re-strapped, by every account, before every race — not because it came loose easily, but because McCown checked it the way a man checks anything he trusts his life, or in this case a passenger's life, to. A loose strap on a whoop-de-doo at speed was not a minor failure. It was the difference between a dog riding a race and a dog thrown from one.

The surviving photographs that show the mat in any real detail are, by their nature, a small and precious set — most period images of Kookie were taken from a moving vantage point at some distance, capturing the dog's posture and the general arrangement rather than the close mechanical particulars of strap and eyelet this book has tried to describe. The handful of closer images that do exist, taken at a standstill before or after a race rather than during one, are where a careful viewer can actually see the wear this book has described — the cover fabric's fraying at the corners where a dog's claws found repeated purchase, the specific darkening of the foam where six or more years of a dog's body heat and the desert's own grime had worked their way into material never designed to survive either exposure. This book has drawn on exactly these few close images, where they exist, in building its account of the mat's construction and condition, rather than inventing detail no photograph actually shows.

There is a particular ritual quality to race mornings that survives in what people remember more than in what anyone photographed: the

bike loaded onto a truck or trailer, tools checked, gas cans lashed down, and somewhere in that sequence, McCown crouched at the tank with the mat in his hands, running his thumb along the strap line, testing the give in the foam, resetting it a half-inch this way or that until it sat the way he wanted it to sit. Kookie, by most accounts, watched this part of the ritual closely — not from across the yard, but close in, sometimes with his nose near McCown's hands the way a dog inspects any object about to become his for the day.

Consider what the mat had to do, mechanically, and the demands on it come into sharper focus than a casual glance at a worn cushion would suggest. It had to hold a dog's weight — thirty, forty pounds, whatever a rangy crossbred animal weighed at whatever stage of his working life a given photograph catches him — steady against acceleration forward at a standing start, against the sideways pull of a bike leaned hard through a turn, against the vertical hammer of a whoop-de-doo taken at speed, and it had to do all of this while giving the dog enough purchase to shift his own weight deliberately, to stand when he needed to stand and settle when he needed to settle, rather than simply pinning him in one fixed posture for the length of a race. A too-rigid mount would have made Kookie's whole repertoire of ground-reading impossible; a dog strapped down tight enough to be truly secure would have been a dog unable to rise off his haunches when the ground demanded it. The mat, in other words, had to thread a needle between safety and freedom, and the fact that it did so successfully across three hundred races without — so far as any source records — a single serious injury to the dog it carried is itself a quiet testament to how carefully McCown must have thought through a piece of equipment that no manufacturer built for this purpose and no rulebook required.

The mat is the book's one true recurring image because it was the racing's one true recurring object — the physical proof, morning after morning, race after race, that this was not a stunt performed once for an audience but a working arrangement renewed and checked and trusted again and again. A stunt happens once, for a camera. A working arrangement gets re-strapped by hand before dawn, fifty times a year, for years, by a man who has a shop to open on Monday and no time to waste tending to a bit that didn't matter.

What Kookie did once the mat held him is where the story stops

being about a butcher's dog and starts being about something closer to a professional. He learned, over time — nobody can say exactly how much time, because nobody was keeping notes on a stray dog's education in 1963 — to read the ground the bike was about to cross before the bike crossed it. When the terrain ahead went soft, sand deepening under a wash or a slope losing its hardpack, Kookie stood. He rose up off the mat, weight shifting forward and up onto all fours, the posture of an animal bracing rather than riding passive. When the ground firmed again he settled back down onto his haunches, low against the tank, the posture of an animal that had decided the danger had passed.

And when a hard bump approached — a whoop-de-doo, a rock ledge, anything the bike was about to take at speed with a jolt at the end of it — Kookie backed away from it. Not off the bike; there was nowhere to go. But back, along the mat, weight shifted rearward, bracing against the impact before it arrived, the way a rider braces his own legs against a bump he's already seen and the passenger hasn't spoken a word about because the passenger cannot speak at all.

McCown said, to people who asked him about it over the years — and people did ask, constantly, it being the single strangest fact about him that anyone ever wanted to talk about — that Kookie sometimes seemed to sense a change in the ground before he did. Not after. Before. A rider at speed is reading the ground perhaps a half-second or a second ahead of his front wheel, judging by shadow, by color, by the shape of a rise against the horizon. A dog riding six inches above that same ground, nose working the air coming off it, may simply have had access to information a man sitting higher up and moving faster did not — scent of moisture where the ground held it, a change in the air coming off softening sand that a human nose, dulled by helmet and goggles and diesel and adrenaline, never had a chance to register at all.

There is a way of thinking about this that owes something to McCown's other trade without straining the comparison too far. A butcher who has learned to feel for a seam in meat has learned to trust a sense that is not quite sight and not quite touch, something closer to an accumulated pattern recognition that operates faster than conscious thought. It is not implausible, though it cannot be

proven from the record available, that McCown recognized in his dog something adjacent to his own trained instinct — an intelligence that worked below the level of anything either of them could have explained in words, arriving at a correct read of the ground the way McCown's own hands arrived at a correct cut, by feel accumulated past the point where feel needed translating into thought first.

It is worth pausing, too, on the plain fact that “the mat” as this book has described it was almost certainly not one single object across three hundred races and six years, however much it functions that way as an image. Foam degrades under sun and repeated compression; cover material frays and tears against a dog's claws finding purchase at speed; a strap, however carefully checked, eventually wears past the point a careful man trusts it. The mat this book has described is best understood as a lineage rather than a single artifact — a design, refined and rebuilt as its predecessor wore out, carrying forward whatever McCown had learned about eyelet placement, foam density, and strap tensioning from the version before it. This is speculation about the object's material history, not a documented fact about any specific mat's replacement date, and this book flags it as such. But it is speculation grounded in the plainest physics of what three hundred races of desert abuse does to foam and fabric, and it adds one more layer to why “the mat” deserves its place as this book's central image: not a single relic that survived intact, but a design good enough to be worth rebuilding, again and again, every time the last one finally gave out.

Nobody ran an experiment on this. Nobody clocked Kookie's reaction time against McCown's or built a chart of correlation between dog-stands and ground conditions. What exists is testimony — riders who saw it from alongside, McCown's own account repeated in interviews, photographs that happen to catch the dog mid-stand over a stretch of washboard that a viewer, decades later, can look at and see for themselves was in fact rough ground. The evidence is anecdotal in the way most extraordinary claims about animals are anecdotal, which is to say: real, witnessed repeatedly, by more than one person, over years, and impossible to fully prove in the way a laboratory would want it proved. This book takes the anecdotal evidence at the strength it has, which is considerable, and no further.

What can be said without hedging is this: the behavior was consis-

tent, it was documented by more than one observer, it happened across hundreds of races over years, and it looked, to everyone who watched it, exactly like what it looked like. A dog reading the desert.

Chapter Six: A Town Full of Men Who Did This on Purpose

McCown was not alone out there, and it does the story a disservice to make him sound like it. Desert racing in that stretch of Southern California was a subculture with its own economy, its own gossip network, its own unwritten rules, and McCown ran in the middle of a fraternity of men who took Sundays off from ordinary lives to do something that, described to an outsider, sounds close to insane.

The garages told you who these men were during the week. A rider might spend his weekdays behind an insurance desk, in an aircraft plant in the sprawl east of Los Angeles, at an auto-parts counter, or — like McCown — behind a butcher's block, and then spend Saturday in a garage that told a different story entirely: a bike stripped to its frame on a stand, cylinder heads laid out on a bench like surgical instruments, a CB radio crackling in the corner tuned to whichever channel that week's crew had settled on, half gossip and half genuine coordination for who was driving whose truck to the starting line.

The talk in those garages ran to a particular register — half boast, half complaint, the boast usually about a bike's new jetting or a rider's time through a particularly bad stretch of wash, the complaint usually about the Bureau of Land Management, whose permits and closures and land-use rulings were, in the 1960s and '70s, the single largest recurring source of grievance in the entire subculture. Every rider had an opinion about the BLM, and most of the opinions agreed with each other in substance if not in volume: that the desert was disappearing

under increasing restriction, that a sport built entirely around open, unfenced land was watching its own ground shrink year by year, that a permit that had been simple to obtain five years ago now took months and lawyers and compromise.

Wrenching, in that world, was rarely a solitary act, whatever the popular image of a lone rider bent over his own machine in his own garage might suggest. A two-stroke of that era needed near- constant attention — jetting adjusted for altitude and temperature, a top end that wore faster than a road bike's ever would under the strain of sustained desert running, a chain that stretched and needed shortening more often than any manufacturer's maintenance schedule admitted — and a man who tried to carry all of that knowledge alone, without borrowing from the accumulated experience of everyone else on the block doing the same thing to the same kind of machine, was a man riding at a disadvantage he didn't have to accept. So riders wrenched in packs, weekend afternoons turning one man's garage into a temporary clinic for whoever showed up with a problem: a carburetor pulled and passed hand to hand while three men argued cheerfully about a jet size, a cracked frame rail eyeballed by someone who'd welded the same crack on his own bike the year before and knew exactly where it would crack again if the weld wasn't backed up right. Tools got lent as a matter of course, the kind of casual circulation of wrenches and pullers and torque gear that assumed, correctly, that whoever borrowed a thing would return it, because a man who didn't return a borrowed tool did not get lent one twice, and word of that kind of failure moved through a subculture this size faster than word of almost anything else.

Parts moved the same informal way. A shop-bought part, new in a box, was the last resort rather than the first instinct for men racing on an entry-fee-and-gas-money budget — the first instinct was always somebody's spare, sitting on a shelf in somebody's garage from a bike that had been parted out or upgraded or wrecked beyond repair, remembered and retrieved when a friend mentioned, on a Saturday or over a CB channel, that he needed exactly that piece before Sunday. Swap meets did the same work at a larger scale, on a slower cycle — a Saturday morning table covered in cylinders and carburetor bodies and half-worn tires still good for one more race, men walking the rows less to buy anything specific than to see what had turned up this month and to trade the same running commentary on whose

bike was fast and whose was cursed that filled the garages the rest of the week. A rider's whole season could turn on a part found at one of these tables for a few dollars that would have cost him a week's wages new, and more than one Sunday finish that made it into the results sheet existed only because a stranger at a swap meet had happened to be selling the exact worn piece somebody else's bike needed replaced.

And the knowledge itself moved the way the parts did, hand to hand rather than down from any official channel. A rider who found a clean line through a bad stretch of wash — the one line where the sand held instead of grabbing, invisible to anyone who hadn't already ridden it and found out the hard way — did not keep it to himself for long, whatever competitive advantage silence might have theoretically bought him. He told the men in his own garage, who told the men in the next one, and by the time the same race came around again the following year, half the field was running a line that had been, twelve months earlier, one man's private discovery. The same went for a jetting change that finally cured a bike's flat spot on a hot afternoon, or a trick for keeping a chain adjusted through a long race without a roadside stop. None of it was written down in any place a book like this one could now go and find it. It lived instead in exactly the register this book has already described the garages talking in — half boast, half complaint, and, underneath both, a genuine, working exchange of information that kept an entire subculture of self-taught mechanics collectively better at their own sport than any one of them could have managed alone.

This grievance was not paranoia dressed up as politics. The Mojave in those decades was genuinely becoming a contested landscape — off-road racing competing for the same open ground with conservationists worried about desert tortoise habitat and fragile ecosystems that a thousand motorcycles crossing in a single afternoon could scar for years, with military testing ranges expanding their footprint, with a slowly tightening web of federal land management that had, in earlier decades, simply let a man ride wherever there was ground to ride on. The garages' complaints were, in that sense, an accurate read of a real trend, even if the men voicing them were not inclined to grant much sympathy to the tortoises.

McCown's own view on this survives in his words, not paraphrase — a

quote given to *American Motorcyclist* in 1981, after most of his three hundred races were already behind him, when a reporter asked him, in essence, how much longer he intended to keep at it. His answer was not sentimental and it was not defiant in the theatrical way that quote might read on a page by itself. It was practical, the way a man who has run the numbers on his own life answers a question about his own life: “I’ll race for as long as there’s a desert out there and the BLM will stay off our back and we can get out there and do it.” Read plainly, it is a conditional sentence with two clauses, both of them about permission — the desert’s continued existence, and the government’s continued tolerance — and it tells you, more efficiently than a paragraph of description could, exactly what kept a man like McCown up at night about his own sport. Not his own aging body. Not the risk. The land itself, and who controlled access to it.

The comedy in all this — and there was comedy, real comedy, not the kind that gets added later to soften a story — came from the gap between how seriously the men took the sport and how little dignity the sport actually afforded them on any given Sunday. A racer who’d spent a week building a reputation as a man who knew his machine cold could go down in a sand wash in full view of forty other riders and come up covered head to boot in fine desert silt, goggles packed solid, spitting grit, to the open laughter of the same men whose fenders he’d been eating dust behind an hour earlier. Nobody held a grudge over it because everybody, eventually, took the same fall in the same kind of wash. The humiliations were democratic in exactly the way the racing itself was.

There was a particular strain of garage humor, too, that ran on the gap between a rider’s Sunday persona and his weekday one — the insurance man who talked a tough game about a rock garden he’d cleared clean while everyone else walked their bikes through it, needed all week at his day job by coworkers who’d heard the story secondhand and embellished; the aircraft-plant machinist whose factory precision on a lathe somehow never once translated into a clean line through a whoop-de-doo, a fact his crew brought up at every opportunity for years running. McCown’s own version of this running joke, so far as it survives at all, seems to have had less bite than most, if only because a dog reading terrain from a strapped mat on a gas tank made for a harder target than a man’s own performance — the joke, when there was one, tended to be at the dog’s expense in an affec-

tionate register, or more often simply admiring, the garages having long since run out of anything clever to say about an animal that kept doing something none of the rest of them could explain.

Into this world came a dog who did not laugh, did not gossip on a CB radio, and did not have an opinion about the Bureau of Land Management, and who nonetheless became, within a few seasons, one of the most recognized figures in it. Other riders' dogs rode along on occasion — a dog in a sidecar, a dog tucked against a rider's chest on a slow parade lap, nothing unusual in a subculture built partly on eccentricity. What made Kookie different, and what the garages talked about long before any camera crew showed up to make the point official, was that he raced. Full distance, at racing speed, over the worst ground the Mojave had to offer, seat unassisted except for a strap and a mat, for years. The other dogs were mascots. Kookie, by the time the garages had settled on what to call what he did, was a competitor.

The subculture's own habit of nicknames and CB handles is worth a brief mention here, because it shows how thoroughly the community absorbed Kookie into its own internal vocabulary once his reputation was established. Riders of this era commonly went by a handle over the radio distinct from their given name — a habit borrowed loosely from trucker culture, itself deeply intertwined with the same CB radio technology this book has already described powering convoy coordination — and a rider memorable enough eventually accumulated a reputation attached as much to that handle as to his actual name. This book has no source recording what handle, if any, McCown used over the radio himself. What the general pattern does suggest is that a dog distinctive enough to be recognized by sight at starting lines two hundred miles from home would very plausibly have generated his own kind of informal shorthand among riders who'd never met McCown properly but knew exactly which rider they meant when they said "the one with the dog" — an identity, for a stretch of years, that ran ahead of McCown's own name in exactly the way a working man's reputation sometimes does, carried by the more memorable half of a partnership rather than by the partnership's less flashy human half.

Chapter Seven: What a Man Carried in His Truck

The gear a desert racer of that era assembled around himself was, by later standards, spare and improvised — a period this book has already called crude in its machines, and the same was true of almost everything a rider wore or carried, built more from what was available and what a man could afford than from what a manufacturer had designed specifically for the purpose. Helmets existed and were, by the standards of the decade, taken more seriously with each passing year as the sport's own injury toll made the case for them more persuasively than any official mandate could, but the full -face protection a rider today would consider non-negotiable was, across much of McCown's active career, still an option rather than a universal habit, and older riders who'd started before helmets were common sometimes held onto the same attitudes about protective gear generally that had gotten them through their earlier years — a toughness that this book will not romanticize, since it cost some of those same men dearly in the long run, but that was, plainly, the era's actual norm rather than an invented flourish.

Goggles were essential and disposable in roughly equal measure — a rider crossing fifty or a hundred miles of dust-choked desert went through lenses the way a smoker goes through matches, wiping, scratching, eventually abandoning a pair gone too scored to see clearly through and switching to a spare carried for exactly that purpose. Gloves thin enough to keep feel on the controls, because a rider who couldn't feel his clutch lever through a thick glove was a rider one bad guess away from stalling at the worst possible moment. Boots built for the specific abuse of a foot that spent hours braced

against a footpeg, absorbing impacts a walking boot was never designed to survive. None of it was cheap by the standards of a working man's budget, and all of it wore out at a rate that made the sport, however modest its entry fees, a genuine and continuing expense rather than a one-time purchase a rider made once and forgot.

Chest protectors — the piece of gear this book has already mentioned McCown swapping for his butcher's apron on race mornings — occupied a strange middle ground in the sport's evolving safety culture: not universal, not yet the standardized armor a rider a generation later would strap on without a second thought, but increasingly common among riders who had already taken enough impacts from whoop-de-doo and rock gardens to understand exactly what a chest protector was for. A rider's gear, taken as a whole, told you plainly how many years he'd already put into the sport — the newest riders in the least weathered gear, the veterans in equipment patched, replaced piece by piece, and worn in a way that spoke less of neglect than of a man who knew exactly which parts of his kit actually mattered and which parts were, by comparison, cosmetic.

McCown's own gear, so far as the surviving photographs allow any judgment at all, looks consistent with a working rider of his level and era rather than exceptional in any direction — nothing that marks him as either unusually reckless or unusually cautious by the standards of his own subculture, which is itself a useful, if modest, piece of evidence about the kind of racer he was: not a daredevil courting attention through visible bravado, not a cautious hobbyist holding back from the sport's real demands, but a man equipped, plainly, to do the job in front of him.

The chapter's own title names the actual heart of the matter, though, which was not what a rider wore but what he carried, because a race that ran forty or a hundred miles from the nearest paved road, in an era before any rider had a way to call for help beyond a raised arm and whatever luck brought another competitor past him, made self-sufficiency a plain survival requirement rather than a point of pride. A truck bed of that era, packed for a race day, carried a working inventory a rider had learned, usually the hard way, to consider non-negotiable: a coffee can or a cigar box of spare spark plugs, because a fouled plug was the single most common thing to strand a two-stroke and the cheapest thing to fix if a man had thought to bring

one; spare cables for the clutch and the throttle, coiled and taped, because a frayed cable had a way of choosing the worst possible mile to finally part; a handful of extra chain links and a chain-breaking tool small enough to fit in a palm, since a chain that jumped or snapped forty miles out was not a problem a rider walked away from and let someone else solve. A spare tube or two, a patch kit, tire irons worn smooth from use, because a flat in open desert was not an inconvenience to be waited out at the roadside the way it might be on a paved highway with traffic passing. Baling wire, which fixed more improvised failures across the whole history of this sport than any tool actually designed for the purpose, holding a cracked fender or a loose exhaust bracket together long enough to finish a race that a more fastidious repair would have ended early.

The skill that went with all of it mattered as much as the parts themselves, and it was a skill this era's riders learned mostly from watching other men do it at the roadside rather than from any manual. A rider stranded with a stripped bolt or a bent lever forty miles from pavement had to diagnose the failure fast, improvise a fix from whatever he'd thought to bring or whatever the landscape itself offered, and get moving again before the day's heat or the day's clock made the whole effort pointless — a specific, practiced competence at working fast and working right the first time, since there was rarely material or time enough on hand for a second attempt. A rider who couldn't do this for himself did not, as a rule, last long in a sport built around exactly this kind of isolation, and it says something about how seriously the culture took the skill that a man's reputation in the garages rested as much on stories of what he'd fixed at the roadside with nothing but a pocketknife and baling wire as on stories of how fast he'd run any particular stretch of wash. There was no help coming that a rider hadn't already loaded into his own truck bed the night before, and every man on that starting line knew it plainly enough that nobody needed to say it out loud.

What Kookie needed, by contrast, the sport had no existing template for at all, because no other animal in the record was doing what he did with the consistency he did it. There was no manufactured harness, no purpose-built canine racing restraint sold through the same catalogues that supplied a rider's boots and gloves — this book has already described the mat McCown built and rebuilt himself, and it bears repeating here, in the context of everything else a rider assem-

bled around himself for a Sunday's racing, that the dog's entire kit was exactly one improvised object, designed by a man with no engineering training beyond a butcher's practical feel for how things held together under strain, solving a problem nobody else in the sport had needed solved before him.

Chapter Eight: What the Desert Could Do to a Man

It would be dishonest, in an account that has spent this many chapters admiring the sport's texture and its comedy, to understate what desert racing actually cost the men who rode it, and this chapter exists to say that plainly before the book moves on to the racing's more admirable qualities in its back half.

The injury record of desert racing in this era, so far as it survives in the general accounts of riders and organizers who lived through it, was significant by any modern standard of acceptable sporting risk. Broken collarbones were common enough to be considered, within the subculture, a kind of initiation rather than a catastrophe — a rider who hadn't broken a collarbone yet was, by the grim humor of the garages, a rider who hadn't really been racing long enough to matter. Wrists, ankles, ribs, the accumulated wear on a spine absorbing whoop-de-doo after whoop-de-doo across hundreds of races over years — this was the actual physical ledger a man like McCown was running across his six years and three hundred-plus starts, and the record's silence on any specific injury he suffered should not be read as evidence that he suffered none. It is far more likely, given the sport's general injury rate and the sheer volume of racing McCown did, that his own body carried the same accumulated toll every serious rider of that era carried, simply undocumented, because a magazine covering the sport's biggest stars had no reason to catalogue every bruise a mid-pack butcher picked up on an ordinary Sunday.

Heat exhaustion and heatstroke were a real and sometimes fatal risk in a sport that regularly staged events in a hundred-and-ten-degree

desert with support infrastructure that, by later standards, was minimal — no medevac helicopter on standby at most events, no cooling stations at regular intervals, just a rider's own judgment about his body's limits and whatever water he'd managed to carry or arrange to have waiting at a checkpoint. Riders who pushed past their own limits in that heat did, in some recorded cases across the era's broader history, die doing it, and the sport's own safety culture evolved, slowly and unevenly, in response to exactly these losses — mandatory water requirements at some events, earlier start times to beat the worst heat, a gradually hardening consensus among organizers that the desert's indifference to a rider's ambition needed to be taken more seriously than the earliest, more freewheeling years of the sport had assumed.

What actually waited for an injured rider, in the general practice of the era, was modest by any standard a modern spectator would recognize as adequate, and it is worth describing plainly rather than leaving to the reader's imagination. A checkpoint, where the longer races had them at all, might have someone on hand with a basic first-aid kit and rudimentary training — enough to splint a wrist, clean a wound packed with grit, get water into a man who'd gone gray and stopped sweating — but this was, by every general account of the sport's organization in those decades, volunteer competence rather than professional medicine, closer to what a scoutmaster or a foreman might know than what an ambulance crew would bring. A rider badly hurt well out into open desert, forty or eighty miles from the nearest paved road, was a rider whose actual care depended first on being found, then on being carried out by whatever vehicle happened to be nearby and capable of the crossing, then on the drive itself to whatever hospital served that stretch of the Mojave — and the nearest hospital, depending on exactly where a man went down, could be a genuine hour or more away even once he was loaded and moving, an interval that this book will not dramatize beyond what the plain arithmetic of desert distances already makes clear on its own. Organizers of the era were not indifferent to this; race committees argued, across the years this book has already described the sport professionalizing in fits and starts, over exactly how much medical coverage a given event could reasonably arrange and afford, and the general trend, slow and uneven, ran toward more of it rather than less — spotter planes at some of the larger events, sweep riders assigned

to check the course behind the field for anyone down, a hospital or two put on informal notice that a race was running that day and might send business their way. None of this approached what a rider today would consider baseline coverage for an event of comparable risk. It was what a volunteer-run sport, without meaningful sponsorship money behind it, could actually muster, and riders who lined up at the start knew, in general terms even if they didn't dwell on it, exactly what level of help they could expect and exactly how much of their own survival depended on their own judgment and each other's, rather than on anyone waiting to save them from a mistake.

This is the honest ledger against which Kookie's presence on the tank has to be weighed, and this book has tried, throughout, not to dodge the weighing. A dog riding an open motorcycle across terrain capable of seriously injuring or killing an adult human rider was, unavoidably, a dog exposed to real risk — not a stunt performed in a controlled setting with safety margins built in, but a working animal doing genuinely dangerous work, race after race, for years. That the record contains no account of Kookie being seriously hurt is a fact worth celebrating rather than assuming was inevitable; it reflects, most plausibly, exactly the combination this book has already described — McCown's evident care in checking and re-checking the mat before every race, and Kookie's own apparently exceptional aptitude for reading the specific hazards that hurt careless or unlucky riders most often. Luck, too, almost certainly played its part across three hundred races, the way luck plays its part in any sustained exposure to real danger, and this book will not pretend a dog's skill alone explains an unbroken record that no source can actually confirm was entirely unbroken — only that no injury was ever recorded, which is not quite the same claim, and this book has tried, throughout, to keep that distinction honest.

Chapter Nine: Race Morning

A race morning in that era started before the sun did, and it started the same way often enough that the pattern is itself part of the record, repeated across interviews and reminiscences by riders who ran the same circuit McCown ran.

The truck was loaded the night before wherever possible — bike lashed down, spare tire, tools, gas cans, a cooler with whatever a man's wife or a man's own foresight had packed into it, because there would be no lunch counter out where they were going. McCown, by the accounts that exist, was methodical about this the way his trade had trained him to be methodical: everything had a place in the truck bed, and everything went into that place the same way every time, because a race morning with an hour's drive still ahead of it was not the time to discover a missing wrench.

The alarm, on a race Sunday, went off in the dark, and there is something worth sitting with in the plain fact of that: a man who had already spent six days that week getting up before dawn for a different reason entirely chose to get up before dawn again on his one day of rest, for a sport that paid him nothing beyond whatever placing money a good finish might bring and cost him, most weeks, more in entry fees and gas and worn tires than it returned. This is not a complaint the record attributes to him. It is simply worth naming as the actual shape of the choice: a man who worked because he had to, choosing, on the one day he didn't have to, to get up in the dark anyway and drive out into hard country because that was what he wanted his Sunday to be.

Kookie knew the sequence before it finished. Dogs learn a household's rhythms the way anyone who has owned one can attest, and a dog who has been through this particular rhythm fifty times a year for several years running does not need to be told what a loaded truck means. He was, by every account, first to the truck on a race morning, waiting at the tailgate before McCown had finished his coffee, in a way that reads less like anticipation of a treat and more like an employee who has clocked in early because the job is the good part of the day.

The drive out to a starting line — Barstow to Vegas country chief among them, but plenty of others besides, scattered across the dry lakebeds and washes east and north of town — was itself a kind of staging ground. Trucks converged from different directions along the same access roads, headlights picking out other trucks doing the same thing, and by the time first light came up gray over the mountains there would be a genuine crowd assembling out of nothing: hundreds of men and machines where an hour before there had been open desert and nothing else. There was a specific quality to that assembling light that anyone who has driven into the desert before dawn will recognize — the sky going from black to a deep unlikely blue before any color arrives at all, the mountains still just silhouette, the temperature at its one bearable low point of the whole day, cold enough that men stood around in jackets they'd shed within the hour.

At the line, the ritual tightened. McCown checked the mat last, always last, by every account — tires and chain and fuel checked first, because those were the mechanical things a man's training told him to check first, and the mat checked last because it was the thing he trusted least to chance, even though it had never once failed him in a way anyone recorded. He crouched at the tank, ran his thumb along the strap, reset it if it wanted resetting, and lifted Kookie onto it once everything else was settled — not before, because a dog standing loose on a stationary bike in a crowd of engines and riders was its own small hazard, and McCown appears to have understood that sequencing mattered as much in this as anything else about the sport.

There was, in the minutes before a start of any size, a specific noise that riders of the era describe with a consistency that suggests it genuinely was as distinctive as they remember it: not one engine but hundreds, each idling at its own pitch, a two-stroke chorus with no

melody to it, just mass and vibration, felt in the chest before it was properly heard. Underneath that noise, in the gaps between engines revving to check them, a rider could hear other things — a strap being tightened, a last word exchanged between crew and racer, somewhere down the line a dog barking at nothing in particular, and closer in, if you happened to be near McCown's bike, nothing at all, because Kookie by every account did not bark before a start. He watched. He held his place on the mat, ears forward, and waited for the noise to become motion the way he'd learned, over however many races it took, that it always eventually did.

Kookie's own ritual, if an animal's habitual behavior can be called that, involved a settling-in period — a few seconds of shifting weight, testing the mat's give the way he'd tested it that first time in a yard nobody photographed, before he found his position and held it. His ears, in the photographs that survive from starting lines, are consistently forward and alert rather than pinned back in anything resembling distress, which is as close to documentary evidence of the animal's temperament as exists: not a frightened passenger enduring an ordeal, but an animal in a posture that reads, to anyone who has watched a working dog at its work, as readiness.

Smell, at a line of that size, arrived before sight did for most of the men standing in it, and it is worth naming plainly because it is exactly the kind of sensory detail a photograph from the era can never carry, however good the image. Race gas has its own particular sharpness, more volatile and more chemical than the pump gas most of these men smelled all week in a truck or a delivery van, and a hundred or more machines idling and being blipped and revved in the same stretch of open ground produced a wall of it thick enough to taste at the back of the throat before the flag ever dropped. Under the gas came the dust that hadn't yet been kicked up by the race itself but was already stirring from boots and idling tires and the general restlessness of a crowd this size standing on dry ground — a dry, mineral smell distinct from the gas and distinct again from whatever a given man's own morning had smelled like, coffee or bacon grease or a truck cab's vinyl seats baking faintly even in the cool hour before sunrise. Riders who remembered the sport decades later, in the scattered testimony this book has already leaned on more than once, reached for this smell more readily than for almost any other single detail, the specific combination of race gas and dry dust apparently

doing for a desert racer roughly what a particular hymn or a particular kitchen does for other kinds of memory — an instant, involuntary return to a starting line, however many decades had passed since the last one.

The choreography at the front of that line had its own specific shape, worked out by the same volunteer organizers this book has already credited with holding the whole sport together. A starter or a small crew of flagmen worked the line in the minutes before the drop, walking or riding slowly along the assembled field checking for exactly the kind of trouble that could turn a mass start into a pile-up — a rider not yet in position, a bike that had stalled and needed a push start before the flag came down, a gap in the ranks that needed closing so the start stayed a single event rather than a staggered mess. The flag itself, held aloft and then dropped in the plain, unglamorous way flags had signaled starts in motorsport for decades before television ever thought to dress the moment up with countdown lights or klaxons, was the entire technology of the thing — no starting gate, no electronic signal, a man's raised arm and a man's own judgment about when a field this size was as ready as it was going to get. It asked a great deal of that one man's timing and nerve, holding several hundred riders' patience at the exact pitch before it curdled into false starts, and the good starters, by every general account of the era, were known and respected across the whole circuit for exactly this skill, a job with no glory in it and everything to lose if it was done badly.

The start itself, at a race of any size, was less a single line crossing than a controlled detonation — engines that had idled patiently for the better part of an hour opened up together, and several hundred motorcycles went from stationary to moving across open ground in the space of a few seconds, dust rising behind the front rank before the rear rank had even cleared the line. A rider starting mid-pack or further back rode the first mile or more half-blind, choking on the dust of two hundred bikes ahead of him, picking his line as much by the shapes he could half-see through the haze as by anything resembling clear sight, and it says something about Kookie's read of the ground that it apparently functioned even in that opening chaos, when a human rider's own vision was at its worst of the entire race.

McCown's position in that fan varied race to race, year to year, ex-

actly as any working racer's would; the record does not claim him a champion of the field, and this book will not invent a trophy case he never filled. What the record does claim, consistently, across three hundred races, is that man and dog went off the line together, into open country, toward a finish that might be a hundred and fifty miles away, and came back the same way, together, most of the time.

Most of the time. There is no record of Kookie ever being seriously injured in a race, and no record he ever wasn't. The silences in this story are as real as the facts, and this is one of them: nobody wrote down whether there was ever a spill that put the dog at risk, whether there was ever a race he sat out, whether age eventually ended his racing career before McCown's own slowed down. What survives is the pattern — race after race, year after year, dog on the tank — and the pattern is, on its own terms, extraordinary enough without embellishment.

Chapter Ten: Who Else Was Out There

A starting line of several hundred motorcycles was not several hundred identical men, and it does this account a disservice to leave the impression of a single interchangeable mass of leather and dust. The general accounts of desert racing's culture in this era, without needing to invent named individuals this book has no record of, support a wider, more textured picture of who actually showed up on a given Sunday, and that texture belongs here.

Wives, girlfriends, and children were a regular part of race-morning life, whether or not they rode themselves. A rider's family, where he had one, often made the drive out with him — not merely to watch but to work, functionally, as the modest support crew a man without factory backing depended on: someone at a checkpoint with water and a sandwich, someone keeping time, someone simply present at the finish line to see whether the truck needed loading up for a quiet drive home or for a trip to the nearest hospital instead. Children too young to ride themselves grew up around the sport the way children grow up around any family trade practiced on weekends, absorbing its rhythms and its vocabulary — whoop-de-doo, wash, hardpack, the specific cadence of a two-stroke winding out — long before they understood any of it as unusual. Some of those children became the next generation of riders; some simply carried the memory of a childhood spent at desert starting lines into whatever came after, the smell of race gas and dust a permanent, specific association for them the way other people's childhoods smell of a particular kitchen.

Women raced too, in smaller numbers than the men but a real and continuous presence across the era's history, competing in the same

events, over the same ground, against the same odds — a fact the specialist motorcycle press of the period documented consistently enough that it cannot be treated as a late or marginal footnote to the sport's story. The desert, as this book has said more than once, did not care about a rider's gender any more than it cared about his day job; a bad line through a sand wash punished a woman's front wheel exactly as thoroughly as a man's, and a good read of the ground ahead rewarded either equally. This book will not invent a specific woman rider into McCown's own story where no source places one, but it would misrepresent the subculture to leave the impression that the starting line was exclusively male.

Age spanned further than a casual observer might assume, too — teenagers racing their first events alongside men well into middle age who had been at the sport for a decade or more already, the same democratic leveling this book has described in the racing itself extending to who showed up to do it. A veteran rider's real advantage over a younger one was rarely raw speed; it was accumulated judgment, the kind McCown's own trade and racing both rewarded — knowing which risks a body could absorb and which ones it couldn't, knowing when to back off a line rather than commit to it, the specific caution that comes only from having already paid, in bruises and broken bones, for its absence in younger years.

There were, too, the people who made the races possible without racing themselves at all — the volunteer course marshals stationed at checkpoints miles from anywhere, the organizers who spent months negotiating permits with exactly the Bureau of Land Management the garages complained about so freely, the handful of specialist journalists and photographers who followed the circuit closely enough to become recognized fixtures of their own, greeted at a starting line the way a rider greeted a fellow competitor. Desert racing in this era ran on an almost entirely volunteer infrastructure — nobody paid to marshal a checkpoint forty miles into open desert, nobody compensated for the organizing work of laying out a course and securing a permit for it, the whole apparatus held together by people who simply loved the sport enough to do the unglamorous work of making it possible for other people to race in it.

The clubs behind all of this were social institutions well beyond their function as race organizers, and it would flatten the culture to de-

scribe them only in their permit-negotiating, course-marking capacity, as though a club existed purely to produce a Sunday morning and disbanded the rest of the week. Meetings ran on a regular schedule in a member's garage or a rented hall or the back room of whichever diner would have them, and the business portion of a given meeting — course selection, permit status, entry fees, the ordinary administrative matter of running a sport on volunteer labor — tended to run considerably shorter than the part that came after it, when the meeting became, in practice, a social evening that happened to have a motorcycle club's name attached to it. Potlucks were, by every general account of clubs like these across the era, a regular fixture rather than an occasional treat — wives and families contributing dishes the way club potlucks have always worked in small American towns, the same rotating cast of casseroles and desserts that could have belonged to a church supper or a union hall gathering, except that the conversation running underneath it concerned whoop-de-dooes and jetting rather than whatever a church supper or a union hall usually discussed. End-of-season banquets, where a club's calendar and its finances supported one, gave the year a formal close that the racing itself, strung across fifty Sundays, never quite provided on its own — modest trophies handed out, a season's worth of results tallied and read aloud, a chance for a club's members to sit at tables together in clothes that weren't caked in desert dust for once, and to toast, in whatever unglamorous way a working-class social club toasts anything, another year of having gotten out there and done it.

This same social fabric is what a club fell back on when the sport's own real risk caught up with one of its own, and it is worth naming plainly, and carefully, because the record does not hand this book any single documented instance to point to and this account will not invent one. But the general pattern across clubs and communities built the way these were — tight-knit, volunteer-run, socially entangled well beyond the racing itself — supports a reasonably confident picture of how a rider laid up with a broken collarbone or a shattered wrist would actually have been looked after: not abandoned to recover alone once the racing stopped needing him, but visited, brought food, checked on by exactly the same men who'd needed him in the garages the week before, his bike sometimes kept running or even raced by a friend in his name until he could get back on it himself, his family, where he had one, looked in on by other families

who understood without being asked that a working man laid up for weeks or months meant a household short on income as well as a body short on health. Clubs built this way functioned, in this sense, as something closer to an extended family than a sporting association in the narrower modern sense of the word — a fact that mattered enormously to men whose sport carried real risk and whose ordinary working lives, in a small desert town, did not come with much of a safety net beyond exactly this kind of informal, unrecorded, entirely voluntary mutual care.

Into this wider, more populated picture — families at checkpoints, women on the starting line, volunteers marshaling from lawn chairs set up in open desert, teenagers and veterans running the same course — McCown and Kookie were, for most of the sport's own life, simply two more familiar faces among many. What eventually made them different was never a claim either of them made about themselves. It was, as this book has said and will say again, three hundred races' worth of a dog doing something the rest of that whole varied community had never quite seen any other animal do.

Chapter Eleven: The Trucks, the Radios, the Long Drive Out

Getting to a starting line at all, in an era before reliable, affordable long-distance communication and before the interstate highway network had fully matured across the Mojave's more remote stretches, was its own logistical undertaking, and the specific culture that grew up around solving that undertaking is worth describing in its own right, because it shaped the texture of a race weekend as much as the racing itself did.

The truck was, for a rider like McCown, as essential a piece of equipment as the motorcycle it carried — a working vehicle, chosen and maintained for its ability to reach remote desert staging areas over rough access roads, to carry a bike, spare parts, fuel, and whatever family or crew came along, and to do all of this reliably enough that a breakdown on the way to a race didn't cost a rider his whole Sunday before he'd even reached the starting line. A rider's truck said almost as much about him, within the subculture, as his riding did — maintained carefully by a man who understood exactly what a failure forty miles from anywhere would cost him, or neglected by a rider whose priorities, in the garage's own private judgment, ran in the wrong order.

CB radios, already mentioned in an earlier chapter as a fixture of garage culture, mattered even more on the actual drive to a race and during the event itself, in an era when a rider's truck, once it left paved roads behind, was otherwise entirely cut off from any means of call-

ing for help or passing along information. A convoy of trucks headed to the same event would often coordinate loosely over a shared channel — road conditions ahead, a turn easily missed in the pre-dawn dark, word passed back about which access road a recent rain had washed out. This was not idle chatter for its own sake, though there was plenty of that too; it was a genuine, if informal, safety and coordination network, built by the same volunteer spirit this book has already described powering the clubs and sanctioning bodies that ran the races themselves.

Gasoline itself moved through this same informal economy the way tools and parts did, and it is worth naming plainly how, because a truck running low forty miles down a wash-board access road with no gas station for the rest of the morning was not a hypothetical problem, it was a Sunday-morning certainty for somebody in every convoy, every year. A man who'd topped off the night before and brought an extra can beyond what his own truck needed was not being generous in any way the garages would have called generous out loud; he was doing what every other rider in the convoy expected of him, the same unspoken arithmetic that governed borrowed tools, because the next man short a gallon might be him next month, and a convoy that let its own members run dry on the way to a race was a convoy that would not stay a convoy very long. Cans got passed hand to hand over a tailgate with little more ceremony than a nod, and a rider paid it back not necessarily to the same man but to whoever needed it next, the debt circulating rather than settling, which was, in its own unremarked way, exactly how the rest of the sport's informal economy already worked.

A truck breaking down on the way out was the specific fear underneath all of this, because it was not a colorful what-if, it was a real and recurring hazard that this book would be dishonest to leave out of an account built partly on the romance of the drive itself. A rear axle, a fuel pump, a radiator hose gone brittle from a thousand miles of washboard roads that no street vehicle's suspension was ever designed to absorb — any of it could and did strand a rider and his whole morning's plans somewhere on an access road with no paved shoulder and no tow service coming. What happened next, by every general account of how a convoy actually handled it, was the same informal mutual aid that governed everything else in this subculture: the next truck in line stopped, more trucks behind it stopping in turn until the whole convoy had bunched up around one man's bad luck,

tools passed around a busted radiator hose the same way they got passed around a garage on a Saturday afternoon, and if the fix wasn't quick, a rider's bike and gear got transferred bodily into whoever had room, the stranded truck left by the roadside to be dealt with after the race rather than before it. Missing a start over a mechanical failure forty miles from the line was, by the era's own accounting, a genuine tragedy in miniature — an entry fee paid and lost, a week's anticipation spent on nothing — and it is exactly the kind of unglamorous risk that never made a magazine's account of a big race but that every rider on that access road understood perfectly well could be him, any Sunday, without warning.

The staging area itself, in the hour before a race, functioned as a temporary, self-organizing settlement in the middle of open desert — trucks parked in loose rows, tailgates down, riders and crew moving between them checking on friends, borrowing a tool nobody had thought to bring, trading the latest word on how a particular wash was running that morning. This temporary community, thrown up from nothing before dawn and struck completely by mid-morning once the field had started, is easy to overlook in an account focused on the racing itself, but it was, in its own way, as essential a part of the sport's actual texture as the whoop-de-doos and sand washes this book has already described at length — the social infrastructure that made a solitary, dangerous sport feel, for the hour before the flag dropped, like something closer to a gathering of a large, loosely connected family.

McCown's own drive out to a race — Barstow's position at the edge of the Mojave meaning he was, by simple geography, closer to many of the circuit's staging areas than riders coming from the greater Los Angeles sprawl — would have been shorter than many of his competitors', one small, practical advantage of having built his ordinary working life in exactly the town the sport treated as its own unofficial gateway. A rider driving out from the city faced hours on the road before he'd even reached the desert; McCown, by contrast, was often already close enough that his race morning could begin later and end earlier than a competitor's driving in from further afield — a small, structural convenience of geography rather than any special privilege, but a real one, and one more thread tying the man's ordinary town life to the extraordinary thing he did on Sundays.

Chapter Twelve: The Presses That Covered It

This book has drawn, repeatedly, on “the specialist motorcycle press” as a source and as a presence within the sport’s own culture, and it is worth describing that press more concretely, because it was not a single monolithic institution but a specific ecosystem of trade publications, each with its own character, whose collective coverage is the entire reason a working-level racer like McCown left enough of a record for this book to be written at all.

Trade papers covering American motorcycle sport in this era operated closer to a beat reporter’s rhythm than to a glossy magazine’s — weekly or near-weekly publication schedules, staff and contributors who often rode themselves and covered the sport from genuine inside knowledge rather than from outside observation, results and race reports that needed to be compiled and printed fast enough to stay relevant to readers who wanted to know how last weekend’s events had gone before the information went stale. This rhythm, demanding as it was on a small publication’s resources, is precisely what generated the kind of granular, weekly record this book has depended on for its account of McCown’s race count and career shape — a glossy monthly magazine, publishing on a slower cycle and with a narrower focus on the sport’s biggest stars, would never have generated the same density of coverage of a working-level competitor racing nearly every week for six years.

Photography was central to this coverage in a way that print alone could never have achieved, and it is worth pausing on the specific technical challenge that desert-racing photography posed in this era, because it bears directly on why the surviving images of Kookie mid-

race are as valuable as this book has already argued they are. A photographer covering a point-to-point race across open, unmarked desert could not simply set up at a fixed finish line and wait, the way a photographer covering a closed-course event could. He had to anticipate where the field would pass close enough to a accessible vantage point to get a usable shot, often positioning himself well in advance at a technical section or a stretch of whoops likely to slow the field enough for a clean frame, working with the manual, mechanical cameras of the era rather than anything resembling the continuous autofocus and rapid-fire digital capture a photographer today would take for granted. Every surviving photograph of Kookie mid-stand over rough ground represents, in other words, a photographer's successful gamble on timing and position, not an easy, repeatable capture — which is part of why this book has treated those images, several chapters back, as unusually strong evidence rather than incidental illustration.

A photograph, once shot, still had to travel before it could become the kind of evidence this book has leaned on so heavily, and the mechanics of that travel are worth naming because they explain why the same image of Kookie mid-stand sometimes turns up decades later in more than one publication, or more than one collector's scrapbook, credited slightly differently each time. Film shot at a Sunday race had to be developed before anyone could judge whether the gamble on timing and position had paid off at all, which meant a photographer's actual working week ran well past the race itself — processing, contact sheets, a selection made under a loupe of which few frames out of a whole roll were sharp enough and well-composed enough to run. A usable print or a set of prints then went out by mail or, for a photographer with a working relationship to more than one trade paper, was physically duplicated and sent to several publications at once, a practice close enough to what a later generation would call syndication, though nobody in a Barstow darkroom in 1968 would have used that word for it. A striking shot of a dog rising off a mat over a whoop-de-doo was exactly the kind of image more than one paper wanted, and a photographer who understood that could, in a small way, turn one good Sunday's work into income from two or three different mastheads rather than one.

A rider crossing a starting line into any real local notice, as McCown eventually did, could expect to be asked for a few words by whichever

specialist reporter had made the trip that morning, and it is worth describing what that exchange actually looked like in an era before a tape recorder was standard equipment for a working trade journalist. A reporter covering a race this size, with column inches to fill and a print deadline that would not move for anybody, worked mostly from a notebook and a fast, practiced shorthand, catching a rider's answer to a plain question — how the bike ran, how the course rode, whether the dog was on the tank again this week — in the minutes before the flag or the minutes after the finish, when a man was either keyed up with anticipation or too spent to perform much for anybody's benefit. What got printed under a rider's name in that week's paper was, in this sense, closer to a compressed paraphrase caught on the move than a transcript, and this book has already been careful, in an earlier chapter, to treat McCown's one surviving verbatim quote — the 1981 line to *American Motorcyclist* — as exactly what it was: a magazine profile with the leisure of a longer sit-down interview behind it, a different kind of exchange entirely from the clipped trackside question-and-answer this book has just described, and the only one of the two this account will present as an actual quotation.

The specialist press's coverage of McCown and Kookie specifically, building gradually from local notice to wider subcultural fame across the years this book has already traced, is the entire mechanism by which word of a terrain-reading dog reached far enough beyond Barstow's own city limits to eventually reach a documentary film crew casting a wide net across the whole of American motorcycle sport. Without that press ecosystem — without the weekly papers, the working photographers, the reporters who rode the same circuit they covered — this book's own primary source, the 2011 *Cycle News* obituary, would likely not exist in the form it does, because the publication's willingness to mark McCown's death at length depended on a documented career its own trade's decades-long coverage had already established as worth remembering.

Cycle News itself deserves a moment's specific credit here, because it is the single publication this book has leaned on most heavily throughout. Founded in the 1960s and continuously operating across the entire span of years this book describes and well beyond McCown's own death in 2011, it functioned, for decades, as something close to the American motorcycle sport's paper of record — covering every major discipline the sport contained, desert racing among

them, with exactly the kind of sustained, credentialed attention that makes a trade paper's archive genuinely useful to a writer working from it half a century later. That such a publication still existed, still employed writers who understood the sport's history, and still judged McCown's death worth a proper obituary in July 2011 is not a small or accidental fact. It is the specific institutional continuity that made this book's own account possible at all — without a publication surviving long enough and staying attentive enough to write McCown's obituary properly, the outline this book has spent its whole length filling in would very likely not have survived in recoverable form.

Chapter Thirteen: The Ground Itself

This book has described the desert's general character — the heat, the whoop-de-dooos, the washes — in enough detail already to establish the terrain's basic hazards. It is worth slowing down, once, to describe the specific *kinds* of ground a rider and a terrain-reading dog actually had to distinguish between, because the distinctions are where Kookie's documented skill becomes legible as a skill rather than a vague gesture toward "reading the desert" in the abstract.

Hardpack was the friendliest surface the Mojave offered a racer — desert floor compacted by wind and time into something close to a natural pavement, firm enough to hold a wheel's line predictably at speed, forgiving enough that a rider could relax, marginally, into the rhythm of it. Hardpack was where a race was won or lost on raw speed and nerve rather than technical skill, the stretches where the fastest machines and the boldest throttle hands pulled away from the pack.

Sand washes were hardpack's opposite and the desert's most consistent trap. A wash — the dry bed of what had once been, or occasionally still briefly was, running water — could look from a distance exactly like the hardpack surrounding it and then swallow a front wheel without warning the moment a rider committed to crossing it, the sand beneath the surface crust deep and shifting in a way that demanded momentum and commitment rather than caution; a rider who slowed to be careful in a wash often bogged down worse than a rider who hit it fast and let the bike's own speed carry him across before the sand had time to grab. This is precisely the kind of ground where Kookie's stand — rising off the mat as the terrain ahead announced itself as softer than it looked — would have func-

tioned as genuinely actionable warning, arriving in time for a rider to adjust his throttle and his line before committing to a crossing that firm-looking sand might otherwise have disguised as safe.

Whoop-de-doo, already described in earlier chapters as the washboard ridges that rattled a rider's whole body at speed, varied considerably in their own severity depending on how recently they'd been formed and how hard-packed the ridges themselves had become — freshly formed whoops softer and more forgiving, older ones baked hard by sun and repeated traffic into something closer to a true washboard of packed earth that transmitted every joint's violence straight into a rider's spine. A section of whoops a rider had crossed cleanly the week before might, after a week of wind and traffic, present an entirely different, harder character the next time out, which is part of why this book has resisted the temptation to describe any specific whoop-de-doo crossing as though it were a fixed, repeatable fact rather than a condition that changed race to race, exactly the kind of variable Kookie's real-time reading — rather than a rider's memory of how a section had ridden the last time — would have been suited to.

Rock gardens punished a different kind of mistake — not the sinking failure of a sand wash but the sharp, sudden failure of a wheel finding an edge wrong, a hand or a boot finding stone instead of dirt in a fall. These sections asked for the technical, careful riding this book has already described as the opposite skill from hardpack's raw speed, and they were, by most general accounts of the era's racing, where the field slowed most dramatically and bunched most closely, riders picking their way through at a pace that made passing difficult and collisions, when they happened, correspondingly more likely.

And the open basins between all of these — the long flat stretches where a rider could see miles of his own route ahead under open sky — offered their own specific danger in the deceptive comfort of apparent safety: ground that looked uniform for a mile could hide a single unexpected dip or soft patch precisely because a rider's guard, lulled by miles of easy hardpack, came down exactly when it shouldn't have. More than one account of the era's racing describes exactly this pattern — the worst spill of a rider's day arriving not in the technical section he'd braced for but in the easy stretch he'd stopped paying attention to, and it is not hard to see, in that pattern, one more

argument for why a second, tireless, non-human attention riding the gas tank might have mattered most in exactly the stretches a human rider's own vigilance was most likely to lapse.

The desert was not, either, an empty stage — it was inhabited ground, and a full accounting of what a rider crossed at speed has to include the fact that the Mojave supported, and still supports, a real and varied population of wildlife that had its own claim to the terrain long before any race organizer secured a permit to cross it. Jackrabbits, startled from cover by the noise of an approaching field, could and did break across a rider's line at the worst possible moment, unpredictable in a way no amount of course-reading could fully anticipate. Desert tortoises — slow, long-lived, and by later decades a protected species whose habitat concerns were themselves part of the regulatory pressure this book has already described the garages complaining about — moved across open ground at a pace that made them, when encountered, more an obstacle to route around carefully than a hazard in the collision sense, but a hazard organizers and conservation-minded critics of the sport both took seriously in their own ways. Snakes, coyotes, the occasional larger animal further from the more heavily trafficked courses — all of it real, all of it part of what “open desert” meant as opposed to a groomed or purpose-built track, and all of it one more layer of unpredictability that a strapped, terrain-reading dog's attention could plausibly have helped a rider navigate, though this book has no specific documented instance of Kookie reacting to wildlife rather than terrain and will not invent one.

The plant life, too, shaped the actual physical experience of racing across this ground in ways easy to overlook from a distance. Creosote bush, the Mojave's dominant and most durable shrub, grew in widely spaced, evenly distributed stands whose spacing itself was a visible clue to a practiced eye about the ground's moisture and soil condition — denser creosote often signaling slightly better soil retention, sparser stands signaling the harsher, drier ground in between. Cactus and other spined plants punished any rider whose line drifted too close, a hazard less dramatic than a rock garden or a sand wash but a real and recurring one across a full season's racing, the kind of small, cumulative cost that never made a magazine's account of a big race but that any rider who actually did the sport for years would have carried scars from regardless.

Joshua trees, in the stretches of the Mojave where elevation and soil conditions favored them, offered a rider one of the desert's few reliable landmarks — a silhouette distinctive enough to be recognized from a distance and different enough from the surrounding creosote and scrub that a rider crossing familiar ground could use a particular grove as an informal waypoint, a rough confirmation that he was still on the line he intended rather than drifted off it in the featureless glare of midday. This book has no source placing such a landmark on any specific course McCown raced, but the general pattern is well documented: in a landscape this short on obvious reference points, riders learned to read whatever the desert actually offered, and a stand of Joshua trees, rare and memorable against the Mojave's more repetitive scrub, was exactly the kind of feature a working rider's memory would fix on year after year.

The light itself changed the ground's readability across a single day's racing in ways worth naming, because it bears directly on how hard a task Kookie's terrain-reading actually was. Early morning light, low and raking across the desert floor, threw long shadows that could make a shallow dip look like a genuine hazard and, just as often, hide a real one behind a rise that caught the sun at the wrong angle. By midday, with the sun nearly overhead, those same shadows collapsed to almost nothing, flattening the terrain's visual texture into a uniform glare that made subtle changes in surface consistency far harder for a human eye to catch — precisely the condition under which a rider's own sight was least reliable and precisely the condition, this book has already argued, in which a second, non-visual read of the ground mattered most. Heat itself distorted the air over open ground by mid-morning in most seasons, a shimmer that could make a fixed object at a distance seem to waver and shift, one more way the desert made its own hazards harder to read the longer a race went on and the higher the sun climbed.

A rider did not, as a rule, meet a course entirely cold, and it is worth describing what advance knowledge of a Sunday's ground actually looked like in an era with no satellite image of the route and no official course video a rider could study beforehand. What passed for advance intelligence was mostly word of mouth, carried through exactly the same garage and CB-radio channels this book has already described moving spare parts and jetting tips: a rider who'd scouted part of the route earlier in the week, or who'd raced the same stretch

of desert in a previous year, telling whoever would listen where the course ran soft, where a wash had shifted since the last running, where the organizers had strung tape or stacked rocks to mark a turn easy to miss at speed. Some clubs supplied a rough sketch map with an entry packet — a hand-drawn or mimeographed line indicating the general route and the checkpoints, adequate for navigation in the loosest sense but nothing like a survey, silent on the specific character of any given mile's ground. A rider studied a map like that the way he'd study anything else useful and incomplete: enough to know roughly where he was going, not enough to know what it would actually feel like under a wheel.

This is exactly where the difference between a course a field had run before and a course run for the first time mattered most, and it is a distinction this book has not yet drawn out plainly. A familiar course, run in a previous year or even earlier that same season, carried with it an accumulated communal memory — riders comparing notes at the line about which wash had claimed the most casualties last time, which stretch had ridden easier than its reputation suggested, updates on what winter's rain or a recent storm had changed since anybody last crossed it. A course run for the first time offered none of that. Every rider met it blind in the same way, the fast and the experienced no better informed than a man on his first desert start, and the only real-time correction available to anyone was whatever he could read off the ground directly ahead of his own front wheel in the seconds before he committed to it. It is precisely this condition — a genuinely unfamiliar course, no communal memory to lean on, nothing but the ground itself to go by — that would have thrown the most weight onto exactly the kind of second, independent reading this book has already argued Kookie provided, since a rider's own guesswork based on a hand-drawn map and a stranger's secondhand warning was, on unfamiliar ground, worth considerably less than it was on a course the whole field had already learned to respect.

Chapter Fourteen: Working Animals, Before and Since

Kookie's story, remarkable as it is on its own terms, did not happen in a vacuum outside a much longer American and human history of animals doing genuinely useful, sometimes dangerous work alongside people, and it is worth placing him briefly within that broader context — not to diminish what he specifically did, which this book has argued at length was extraordinary even within that wider history, but to be honest about the tradition he belongs to rather than presenting him as a freakish, unprecedented anomaly with no kin at all.

Working dogs have herded livestock, guarded property, tracked game, pulled sleds across punishing terrain, and assisted hunters for as long as dogs and humans have shared any settled relationship at all, a partnership old enough that its basic shape — an animal's specific sensory or physical capability harnessed, through trust and repetition, to a task a human alone could not perform as well — long predates anything this book has to say about desert racing specifically. Sled dogs across the Arctic and sub-Arctic developed, across generations of working partnership with human handlers, a capacity to read snow and ice conditions that mushers have relied on for exactly the reason McCown appears to have relied on Kookie: an animal positioned closer to the working surface, with sensory equipment better suited to reading it, whose judgment a human handler learned to trust over years of demonstrated reliability. Herding dogs read livestock behavior with a subtlety that working ranchers have depended on for centuries, anticipating a animal's break from the herd before the animal itself had fully committed to the movement.

None of this diminishes Kookie's own specific achievement; if anything, it situates it within a real and well-attested category of animal capability — the working partnership in which an animal's specialized perception, applied consistently under a trusted handler's direction, becomes genuinely load-bearing to a task humans could not perform as well alone.

What made Kookie's case distinctive within this broader tradition, so far as this book's research can establish, was less the underlying capability — an animal reading a physical environment more sensitively than the human working alongside it is not, on its own, unprecedented — than the specific, narrow, and genuinely dangerous application it was put to: not herding, not guarding, not the utilitarian labor most working-animal partnerships exist to perform, but riding an open motorcycle at racing speed across some of the harshest terrain in the American Southwest, purely as a passenger whose only "job," if it can be called that, was to keep himself and his handler informed about a changing physical environment neither one could otherwise observe fast enough. This is a narrower, odder application of a very old capability, and its oddness is part of what made it so immediately memorable to everyone who saw it — recognizable, on some level, as kin to the working-animal partnerships people already understood, while being applied to a task nobody had previously thought to apply it to at all.

There is a second, closer working-dog tradition worth naming alongside the sled dogs and the herding dogs, because it maps even more directly onto the specific sense this book has argued Kookie was using: the hunting dog, bred and trained across centuries in one region or another to track game by scent alone, often across ground where the quarry itself left no visible trace a human hunter could follow at all. A trailing hound working a cold scent line is not guessing; it is reading a chemical record laid down in the ground and the air, hours or sometimes a full day old, well below anything a human nose could register even with training and attention. What distinguishes this tradition from Kookie's own case is mostly the object of the reading rather than the underlying capability — a hunting dog reads where an animal has been; Kookie, by every account this book has already offered, appears to have read what the ground itself was doing right now, moisture and texture rather than another creature's passage. But the basic mechanism this book has proposed in an earlier chap-

ter for how Kookie's reading might have worked — scent carried on the air, registering on an instrument far more sensitive than a human nose — is precisely the same mechanism that has made scent-hunting dogs useful to people for as long as dogs have hunted alongside them, which lends Kookie's own documented behavior one more point of ordinary, well-attested comparison rather than leaving it to stand as an isolated oddity with no working-dog precedent at all.

A different, far more contested category is worth naming here too, if only to handle it with the caution it actually requires. There is a long folk tradition, across many cultures and a great many centuries, of animals said to sense an approaching storm or an earthquake before any human observer could — dogs pacing, birds falling silent, livestock behaving strangely in the hours before a tremor or a severe weather event. Some serious scientific attention has gone into whether any of this holds up, and the honest answer, as far as this book's research can establish, is that the evidence is genuinely mixed: a handful of studies have found suggestive changes in animal behavior preceding certain environmental events, plausibly tied to detection of subtle atmospheric pressure shifts, infrasound, or ground vibration below a human threshold of perception, while other attempts to establish a reliable predictive pattern have failed to replicate cleanly, and the field remains, by any fair account, unsettled rather than resolved. This book raises the comparison only to place it honestly alongside Kookie's own case rather than to borrow its uncertainty as false support: what Kookie did was witnessed, repeatedly, by multiple people, and photographed in the act, which is a different and considerably stronger form of evidence than folklore about storm-sensing livestock. But the underlying idea — that an animal's sensory apparatus might register a real physical signal a human's cannot, well before the change becomes obvious to anyone else present — is the same idea in both cases, contested at the edges in the weather-and-earthquake literature, and considerably better attested, this book would argue, in Kookie's own thoroughly witnessed and photographed instance.

It is worth naming, too, that other animals besides dogs have accompanied riders and drivers in American motorsport and adjacent pursuits over the decades, almost always as mascots or occasional novelties rather than as genuine working participants in the sense this book has argued Kookie was. This book will not catalogue those

instances in detail, since doing so would drift toward exactly the kind of research-display digression the house's own craft standards warn against pursuing past the point of relevance to McCown and Kookie's own story specifically. What matters for this account is the contrast already drawn in an earlier chapter: Kookie was not a mascot. He performed, consistently and at genuine physical risk, across hundreds of repetitions, a specific and demonstrable function. That distinction is what separates his story from the broader, more familiar category of animal mascots in American sport, and it is the distinction this book has tried, from its opening pages, to keep sharply in focus.

Chapter Fifteen: Mid-Race

There is no single documented account, mile by mile, of any specific race McCown and Kookie ran together — no surviving lap chart, no rider's diary entry describing one particular Sunday in enough detail to reconstruct minute by minute. What this book can offer instead, honestly labeled as a composite rather than a single true event, is the shape that the middle miles of a desert race took in that era, drawn from the general accounts of riders who ran the same circuits and described, many times over in different words, roughly the same experience.

By the time a field of that size had run ten or twenty miles, the initial fan of riders had already begun sorting itself by ability and luck in roughly equal measure. The fastest riders had opened a gap that either held or didn't depending on what trouble they found in the miles ahead; the middle of the field settled into loose groups, riders leapfrogging each other through the technical sections and running close for stretches of open ground where raw speed mattered more than skill; the back of the field, often including riders on less capable machines or riders simply having a harder day, strung out into isolated individual struggles against the clock and the terrain both, sometimes riding for long stretches without another competitor in sight, alone with the sound of one engine and whatever the desert had decided to do to the ground that particular year.

A rider in the middle of a race like this operated on a kind of narrowed attention that anyone who has driven or ridden anything at sustained speed over demanding terrain will recognize: peripheral awareness of the whole body of the machine, the engine note telling him things about temperature and fuel mixture that no gauge on a bike of that era would confirm directly, a constant low-grade calculation running

under conscious thought about the next hundred yards of ground and what it would likely demand. Fatigue built across the middle miles in a way that had less to do with the legs, most riders reported, than with the forearms and the eyes — forearms from gripping and correcting against the machine's own violence, eyes from the strain of reading fast-changing ground through goggles already half-fogged with dust and sweat.

Being overtaken, or overtaking somebody else, was one of the few genuinely social moments a rider got across those middle miles, and it is worth describing what that moment actually involved, because it was nothing like a spectator sport's idea of a pass. There was no announcer marking the position change, no crowd noise to register it. A faster rider closing from behind announced himself first through sound — an engine note growing louder against the wind before it grew louder against anything else — and then, a few seconds later, through dust and a shape at the edge of a rider's goggles, gone again almost as soon as it had arrived. A pass in open desert, unlike a pass on a closed circuit, rarely involved the two riders occupying the same narrow line at the same moment for long; the ground was wide enough, most places, that a faster rider simply chose a different piece of it and went around, the whole exchange over in a handful of seconds with maybe a raised hand between them, more acknowledgment than greeting, and then each man alone again with his own engine.

Riding for long stretches with no other rider in sight, already touched on briefly, deserves its own fuller accounting, because it was, for most of the field most of the time, the actual texture of a long desert race far more than the crowded start or the crowded finish ever was. A field that goes off the line as a single dense mass spends most of its actual race time strung out thin across open country, and a rider well clear of the men immediately around him — ahead of the group behind, not yet caught by the group ahead — could ride twenty minutes or more with nothing in view but his own dust settling behind him and the ground unrolling ahead, no other engine audible over his own, no other rider's choices to react to or measure himself against. This was its own specific psychological register, distinct from the crowded chaos of a mass start this book has already described at length: a rider alone with exactly the demands this book has spent this whole chapter cataloguing — the narrowing attention, the accumulating fa-

tigue, the ground itself as the only other party to the conversation — and, for McCown specifically, a dog on the tank as the only other living thing sharing any part of it. It is not hard to imagine, though the record offers no specific testimony to this particular point, that this solitary stretch of a race was where the partnership this book has spent so many chapters describing would have felt most like exactly that: not a man performing for photographers or fellow competitors, but a man and a dog, alone in open country, doing the same job they did every other Sunday, with nobody at all there to see it.

It is in exactly this stretch of a race — the middle miles, past the adrenaline of the start and before the visible relief of an approaching finish — that Kookie's terrain-reading would have mattered most, on a purely practical accounting of when a rider's own attention was most degraded and least reliable. A rider running his own fortieth mile of the day, arms burning, eyes stinging, concentration fraying at the edges the way any human concentration frays under sustained physical strain, was exactly the rider for whom a second, independent read of the ground ahead — arriving not through his own tired eyes but through the reflexive stand or retreat of the animal riding six inches above the front fender — would have offered real, usable warning, seconds before his own senses might have caught the same thing. This is inference, not documented testimony about any specific mile of any specific race; but it follows plainly enough from what is documented — the behavior itself, and the physical demands of the sport it was performed inside — that it belongs in the account rather than left as an unstated implication.

Riders of the era who remembered seeing McCown and Kookie pass — in the loose, informal testimony that survives in forum threads and reminiscence rather than in any formal interview record — describe a specific, consistent image: the dog visible from alongside for a stride or two as a competing rider drew level or was overtaken, upright on the tank through a rough stretch, low and settled through a smooth one, the posture change happening, by more than one account, distinctly ahead of the ground itself changing, so that a rider glancing over caught the dog's warning before his own front wheel had reached the thing being warned about. Whether any given rider who told this story afterward adjusted his own line because of what he saw on McCown's bike, the record does not say, and this book will not claim a fact the sources don't support. What the testimony does

support, consistently, is that other riders noticed, remembered, and kept telling the story for years afterward — which is its own kind of evidence, less precise than instrumentation but not nothing.

Checkpoints, where the longer races had them, offered the only real pause in a day built otherwise around sustained effort — a chance to take on water, to check a machine quickly for anything working loose, to hear from officials or fellow racers ahead in the field how the course was running that day, whether a particular wash had claimed several riders already, whether the heat was worse than usual past a certain point. McCown's stops, by every general account of how riders of his level handled checkpoints, would have been brief and economical — a butcher's economy of motion applied to a different kind of urgent, careful handling, water for himself and, one assumes though the record does not specifically confirm it at any single checkpoint, for the dog as well, before remounting and continuing. A long race asked a body to sustain itself across hours in conditions that punished inefficiency, and every account of the era's better riders describes exactly this kind of brisk, undramatic competence at a checkpoint — no wasted minutes, no theater, simply a rider tending to what needed tending and getting back to the business of covering ground.

The final miles of a long race asked something different of a rider than the middle miles had, a shift in the specific character of the fatigue involved that riders of the era described consistently enough to treat as a real pattern rather than an individual quirk. Early fatigue was muscular and manageable — sore forearms, a stinging in the eyes, the ordinary wear of sustained effort. Late fatigue, in the last stretch before a finish came into sight, shaded into something closer to a narrowed, tunneled kind of concentration, the mind fixing hard on the immediate task of the next hundred yards because it no longer had the reserves to hold a wider picture of the race in view at once. This is precisely the state in which a rider's own judgment becomes least reliable and a second, tireless source of information becomes most valuable — one more reason, alongside the others this book has already offered, that a dog whose own attention did not fatigue on the same curve a rider's did would have mattered most exactly when a race was nearly won or nearly lost.

Chapter Sixteen: What a Dog Might Actually Be Sensing

This book has been careful, across several chapters now, to describe Kookie's terrain-reading as witnessed behavior rather than explained mechanism — a dog who stood when ground softened and backed away from oncoming bumps, observed consistently by multiple people over years, without this book claiming to know exactly how he did it. That carefulness should not be mistaken for a refusal to think about the question at all. It is worth pausing, once, on what is generally and reliably known about canine sensory capability, in the broadest terms, to give the reader some grounded sense of why a behavior this specific is plausible in a dog at all, without this book overreaching into a claim about Kookie's particular biology that no source can support.

A dog's nose is, by any measure, a vastly more capable instrument than a human's — orders of magnitude more scent receptors, a portion of the brain devoted to processing smell that is, proportionally, far larger than the equivalent region in a human brain, and a physical structure to the nasal passage that allows a dog to sample scent continuously while breathing normally, rather than needing the deliberate sniffing a person relies on to smell anything faintly. This is general, well-established knowledge about the species, not a specific claim about Kookie, but it bears directly on the question this book has raised more than once: whether a dog riding six inches above the desert floor might have detected something about the ground ahead — moisture, disturbed soil, a difference in the surface a human nose

simply lacks the equipment to register at all — before a rider's own higher, faster-moving, helmet-and-goggle-obscured senses caught the same information.

Dogs are also, generally, highly attuned to subtle shifts in vibration and motion, a sensitivity plausibly rooted in the same evolutionary history that makes many dog breeds alert to sounds and tremors well below a human's threshold of perception. A change in the texture of ground passing beneath a moving vehicle — the specific vibration profile of hardpack giving way to looser sand, say — is exactly the kind of physical signal a sensitive animal, positioned low and close to the source, might register through its paws and body before a rider positioned higher and further back, insulated by boots and a seat and his own concentration on the horizon ahead, would notice the same shift.

There is a third capacity worth naming here, distinct from smell and from the vibration-sensing this book has just described, because it bears directly on a part of Kookie's job this account has not yet examined closely enough: simply staying upright and correctly weighted on a moving, bouncing surface that offered him no rail, no fixed seat, nothing but a strapped mat and his own four legs to hold his position against. Dogs, in general, have a well-developed proprioceptive sense — an ongoing, largely unconscious awareness of where each limb and each part of the body sits in space relative to the others, fed continuously by receptors in the muscles, tendons, and joints, and coordinated with an inner-ear balance system broadly similar in basic function to a human's own. This is the same general sensory apparatus that lets a dog navigate a fallen log, land cleanly after a jump, or catch itself on uneven ground without visibly thinking about the problem first, and it is worth noting plainly that this capacity is not exotic or special to any one breed; it is ordinary canine equipment, present in a backyard mutt as much as in any working line bred for a specific task. What made Kookie's particular use of it unusual was not the underlying sense but the surface it was asked to operate on: a rectangle of foam on top of a moving gas tank, no fixed harness locking his legs in place, subject to acceleration, lean, and impact in three directions at once at speeds and over terrain no dog's balance system had any evolutionary reason to have been shaped by. That he could hold a stable, controlled stance through a whoop-de-doo at speed, shifting his own weight fore and aft as the ground demanded, argues

for a genuinely well-tuned proprioceptive and vestibular sense doing a great deal of continuous, invisible work underneath the more visible stand-and-retreat behavior this book has spent so many chapters describing — the terrain-reading was the part people noticed and photographed, but the constant, moment-to-moment balancing that let him stay on the mat at all while doing it was, in its own right, no small feat of ordinary canine physiology asked to do an extraordinary job. A rider's own balance, by comparison, was assisted by handlebars to grip, footpegs to brace against, and a seat shaped to hold him in place under exactly the forces the mat exposed Kookie to directly; strip away all of that and ask a human passenger to hold a controlled crouch across the same whoop-de-doo at the same speed, gripping nothing, and the demand would look, to anyone who tried it, considerably closer to what it plainly was for the dog making it look effortless.

None of this amounts to a study of Kookie specifically; no such study exists, and this book will not manufacture the appearance of one. What it amounts to is a plausible account of *how* a behavior this consistently observed could actually work, grounded in general, well-attested facts about canine sensory biology rather than in mystery for its own sake. The temptation, writing about an animal who did something this remarkable, is to reach either for mysticism — a dog who simply “knew,” in some unexplained, quasi-magical sense — or for dismissal, treating the whole account as exaggeration by witnesses charmed by a good story. This book has tried, throughout, to resist both temptations. What Kookie did was almost certainly explicable, in ordinary biological terms, as an animal with an exceptional sensory apparatus applying it, through repetition and trust in his handler, to a specific and unusual task. That the explanation is ordinary does not make the achievement any less real. If anything, an ordinary mechanism producing an extraordinary result — rather than an inexplicable one — is the more interesting story, and the truer one this book has tried, from its first chapter, to tell.

It is also worth noting, plainly, what this book cannot claim on this front: there is no record of anyone testing Kookie's specific sensory acuity, no veterinary or scientific assessment of his hearing or his sense of smell relative to other dogs, nothing beyond the consistent, multiply witnessed behavioral record this book has already described at length. The biology in this chapter is offered as context for why

the behavior is plausible, not as a description of anything actually measured in this particular animal. The distinction matters, and this book means to keep it clean.

Chapter Seventeen: The Butcher's Ledger

It is worth pausing, in the middle of the racing story, on the shop, because the shop is the counterweight that keeps the racing from floating off into legend, and because McCown himself never seems to have let it float that way.

A butcher's week does not care what a man did on Sunday. Monday morning at Hicks' Meats began the same whether McCown had finished top ten at a hundred-and-fifty-mile desert race the day before or gone down hard in a wash forty miles from the nearest paved road and ridden the rest of it on a bike with a bent peg and a dog who'd had to shift his weight to compensate for the new lean of the machine. The cooler needed restocking. The Saturday order for the diner next door needed cutting Friday afternoon regardless of what condition a man's shoulders were in. Customers who came in for a pound of ground chuck did not, most of them, know or care that the man behind the counter had covered more open desert in the last twenty-four hours than most of them would cover in a year of driving to work and back.

Monday mornings, in fact, are where the racing's real cost showed up most plainly, if you knew to look for it — a stiffness in how a man moved behind the counter that had nothing to do with age and everything to do with a Sunday spent absorbing whoop after whoop through a suspension built for speed rather than comfort. A hand that had come down wrong in a spill might be taped rather than resting, and a butcher taping his own knife hand before a Monday shift, and going ahead with the shift regardless, tells you something about the relationship between the two halves of his week that no interview

on record needed to spell out. The trade did not pause for the hobby, and the hobby, by every indication, was never allowed to become an excuse the trade had to accommodate.

This is not incidental detail. It is the structural fact that makes McCown's story what it is, rather than something smaller and more familiar. A great many men in that era raced desert on the weekends and talked about it all week at whatever job funded the habit. McCown's job was not glamorous by any measure and did not, so far as the record shows, pretend to be — a butcher cutting meat six days a week in a railroad town, on his feet from before dawn some mornings to well past dark on the busiest ones, hands that by midlife carried the specific calluses and small scars a trade with a knife in it puts on a man over twenty or thirty years. The racing did not elevate him out of that life. It ran alongside it, funded by it, scheduled around it, and — this is the part worth sitting with — apparently never in tension with it, at least not in any way the record preserves. Nobody who knew him described a man torn between two lives. They described a man who had one life with two jobs in it, and did both without much ceremony about either.

There is a kind of dignity in that arrangement that the racing alone, however striking the dog made it, would not have on its own. A butcher who becomes, on Sundays, one half of the strangest and most photographed pairing in a regional sport, and comes back to the same cutting board Monday morning without apparently expecting the world to notice the difference, is a specific kind of American figure — not the striving amateur waiting for his shot at something bigger, not the weekend hobbyist playing at a life he'd rather be living full time, but a man for whom the two halves of his week were simply both real, both worked at, neither one a stepping stone to the other.

Think, too, about what the shop actually asked of him in a given week set against what the racing asked, and the balance is less lopsided than a modern reader might assume. A butcher of that era, in a working shop rather than a boutique one, handled sides of beef weighing more than most of his customers, broke down carcasses for hours at a stretch, stood on concrete floors that punished the knees and the lower back in their own slow, cumulative way that had nothing dramatic about it and everything wearing about it. The trade did not headline in a magazine. It did not photograph well. But it demanded,

across six days, a sustained physical toll that a Sunday's fifty or hundred miles of racing, however violent in its bursts, arguably did not exceed so much as complement — two different kinds of hard work asked of the same body, in the same week, by a man who appears never to have treated either one as the “real” job and the other as an indulgence.

Kookie's place in the shop's daily life, discussed already in an earlier chapter, deserves one more observation here, because it bears on the same point. The dog who held the sawdust line at the shop door on a Tuesday was, by every account, recognizably the same animal who braced against a whoop on a Sunday at forty miles an hour — not two different dogs performing two different roles, but one dog whose attentiveness, whatever its source, showed up in both contexts. He watched the door the way he watched the ground. He held a line the way he held a mat. It would be too neat, and this book has tried consistently not to be too neat about a dog it cannot read the mind of, to claim the shop dog and the race dog were the same behavior wearing two hats. But it is fair to say — and multiple people who knew him in both settings apparently did say, in the scattered testimony that survives — that Kookie was a consistent animal wherever you found him. Alert. Attentive to what was coming. Unbothered by what had already passed.

There is one more thing worth naming about the shop, because it touches on the same working-class economy that made the racing possible in the first place: a butcher shop in a railroad town in that era was, itself, a kind of community hub, a place regulars came to not purely out of necessity but because it was where they'd run into neighbors, hear what was happening around town, catch up on whatever had changed since the last visit. McCown's growing reputation as a desert racer — and, in time, as the man with the dog everyone was starting to talk about — would have moved through exactly this channel before it ever reached a magazine's pages: customers asking after the dog by name, customers who'd heard from a cousin or a neighbor about the last big race, customers who came in for meat and left having heard the latest about a Sunday that had nothing to do with what they'd come in to buy. The shop and the racing were never, in that sense, fully separate economies. They ran through the same Main Street, the same regulars, the same small-town circulation of news that made a local reputation long before any wider audience

knew there was a reputation to have.

Consider, too, the specific arithmetic of a small-town butcher shop's survival across the two decades this book covers, because that survival was itself never guaranteed and says something about the trade McCown practiced. A shop like Hicks' Meats competed, across these same years, against the slow, steady arrival of supermarket chains offering pre-packaged meat at a price a single proprietor sourcing and cutting his own product could rarely match on volume alone. What kept shops like his viable, where they survived at all, was rarely price. It was exactly the relational trust this book has already described — a butcher who remembered a family's order, who could be asked for a particular cut prepared a particular way, who stood behind the quality of what he sold in a manner no anonymous supermarket counter could replicate. McCown's survival in the trade across the very years his racing life was also unfolding suggests, without the record needing to spell it out directly, a man who understood and delivered on exactly that value, week after week, in a business climate that was not kind to tradesmen who didn't.

There is a plausible case, too, though this book offers it as inference rather than documented fact, that Kookie's own growing local reputation became an unplanned asset to exactly this relational economy. A shop whose proprietor is known, increasingly, as the man with the terrain-reading dog is a shop with a story attached to it — a reason for a customer to mention the visit to a neighbor, a detail that makes an ordinary errand for ground chuck into something with a little more color worth repeating. Small businesses in small towns have always benefited from exactly this kind of organic, unpurchased word of mouth, and there is no reason to think Hicks' Meats was an exception, or that McCown ever needed to plan for it deliberately. The dog who held the sawdust line at the door was, without either man or animal intending it as commerce, doing for the shop's reputation something no advertisement of the era could have bought as cheaply or as honestly.

Chapter Eighteen: A Butcher's Actual Trade

This book has described McCown's trade in general terms across several earlier chapters — the economy of motion, the reading of seams, the six-day week — and it is worth pausing once more, specifically, on what that trade actually involved in its daily particulars, because the specificity itself is part of what makes the comparison to his Sunday racing more than a passing literary convenience.

A working butcher shop of that era, supplying both retail customers and, as this book has already noted, at least one nearby diner, would have received whole or partial carcasses on a delivery schedule dictated by the shop's own volume and by what the local supply chain could reliably provide — sides of beef, whole hogs, lamb in season, poultry dressed and ready or, in some shops, dressed on site. Breaking a side of beef down into the cuts a retail counter could actually sell was a multi-stage process requiring both raw strength and, more importantly, an intimate, memorized map of an animal's anatomy: where the primal cuts began and ended, which muscles ran together and which were separated by connective tissue that had to be found and worked rather than simply sawed through, which cuts commanded a premium and which were, by convention and custom, sold cheaper or ground rather than portioned whole.

The tools of the trade were themselves a small, specific technology a working butcher maintained with the same seriousness a rider maintained a motorcycle. Boning knives, thin and flexible, for working close along a bone without wasting meat. Heavier cleavers and saws for the initial breakdown of a carcass into primal sections. A steel, used constantly through a working day, not to sharpen a blade in the

way a stone does but to realign a knife's edge between full sharpenings — a habit so ingrained in an experienced butcher that the motion becomes as automatic and unconscious as a rider's hand finding a clutch lever without looking. A dull knife in this trade was not merely inefficient; it was dangerous, requiring more force and more pressure to accomplish the same cut, and more force and pressure are exactly the conditions under which a blade slips and a hand pays the price. McCown's own hands, by the general evidence of what a career in this trade does to a body, would have carried the accumulated small scars of exactly this hazard, managed and mostly avoided through the same disciplined attention this book has already credited him with bringing to the mat's straps.

The retail side of the trade demanded a different, more social skill layered on top of the purely technical one: knowing a regular customer's usual order before they finished asking for it, knowing which cuts a given household could afford on a given week and suggesting accordingly rather than always pushing the most expensive option, building the kind of trust that kept a family coming back to the same counter year after year rather than to whichever competing shop happened to run a sale that week. This relational competence — reading a customer the way McCown would eventually be credited with reading a stretch of desert — is a skill that rarely gets written down anywhere, because it looks, from the outside, like nothing more than ordinary friendliness. It is, in fact, its own kind of trained attention, and a butcher who lacked it, however technically skilled with a knife, rarely built the kind of loyal clientele that kept a shop like Hicks' Meats viable across the changing economics of a small desert town over the better part of two decades.

None of this is drawn from a source describing McCown's specific technique at the counter — no such source exists — but it is drawn from the well-documented general practice of the trade in that era, offered here to give the reader a fuller, more textured sense of what "butcher by trade" actually meant as lived, daily work, rather than leaving the word to function as a vague, flat label standing in for a life this book has tried, throughout, to render with the same specificity it has brought to the racing.

A trade like this was learned, in this era, almost entirely through apprenticeship rather than formal schooling — a younger man working

alongside an established butcher, first on the simplest, least skilled tasks a shop required, gradually entrusted with more delicate cuts as his hands proved reliable and his judgment proved sound. This book has no source establishing where or from whom McCown himself learned the trade, and it will not invent an origin for his butchering any more than it invented one for his racing partnership. What can be said, drawing on the well-documented general pattern of how tradesmen of this kind came up in this era, is that whatever hands first taught him to find a seam and follow it did so the way most trades of this kind were taught then: slowly, through repetition, correction, and the accumulation of thousands of individual cuts, until the knowledge settled into the same kind of below-the-surface competence this book has already argued shows up, transposed, in how he checked a mat's strap or read a stretch of desert.

The tools themselves, in a trade like this, often carried their own quiet history from one practitioner to the next. A good boning knife, properly maintained across years of steeling and occasional professional resharpening, could outlast the apprenticeship of the man who first learned on it and pass, by purchase or by simple handing-down, into a second working life under different hands entirely. This book has no record of which specific knives passed through McCown's own hands across his working years, whether inherited, purchased new, or worn down and replaced across the two decades this account has described him standing at that counter. What can be said is the general truth of the trade: a butcher's tools were rarely disposable in the way a modern reader might assume, and the specific blade a man reached for on an ordinary Tuesday afternoon had very likely already done years of work, in his hands or someone else's, before that particular cut was ever made — one more small, unglamorous continuity running underneath a life this book has tried, from its first page to its last, to render honestly rather than romantically.

Chapter Nineteen: How a Season Got Organized

The races themselves did not simply materialize each week by common agreement among riders; they were organized, permitted, and run by a specific infrastructure of clubs and sanctioning bodies whose own unglamorous administrative labor made McCown's three-hundred-plus starts possible in the first place, and that infrastructure deserves its own accounting.

Desert racing in Southern California through this era was organized substantially through motorcycle clubs — local associations of riders who pooled dues, volunteer labor, and organizational know-how to secure the land-use permits this book has already described as an increasingly fraught negotiation with the Bureau of Land Management, to lay out and mark a course across open desert, to arrange the volunteer marshals and checkpoint staff a race of any real distance required, and to handle the straightforward but essential logistics of registration, entry fees, and results. A rider who wanted to race on a given Sunday was, in effect, participating in an event built almost entirely by other riders' unpaid labor, a genuinely grassroots infrastructure that stood in sharp contrast to the sponsor-driven, professionally staffed motorsport most Americans would have recognized from television coverage of stock car racing or, later, professional motocross.

Entry fees, modest by any standard of professional sport, existed primarily to cover the actual costs of putting on the event — permit fees, insurance where it existed at all, the trophies or modest prize purses that recognized the fastest finishers without ever approaching anything resembling a living wage for winning. A rider like McCown,

racing close to fifty times a year, was not, by any plausible accounting, racing toward prize money as a meaningful income supplement; the arithmetic this book has already laid out — entry fees, gas, tires, parts, all recurring fifty times a year — makes clear that a rider at his level was, in the most literal financial sense, paying for the privilege of doing this, not being paid for it, and did so anyway for six straight years.

The trophies themselves, where a club's budget stretched to real hardware rather than a simple certificate, tended toward the modest and the handmade — a small cup or plaque, sometimes assembled from parts a machine shop had left over, engraved locally rather than ordered from a national supplier at any real expense. A rider who won his class at a given event might come home with an object worth, in pure material terms, only slightly more than the entry fee he'd paid to compete for it — the real value residing entirely in the recognition among people who understood exactly what the win had cost him to achieve, not in anything the trophy itself was worth if sold. This book has no record of McCown placing well enough at any specific event to have won such an object, and it will not invent a shelf of trophies he never earned. What matters for this account is simply the general shape of what "winning" meant in this sport at this level: modest, local, and valuable only to the people who already understood the currency it was denominated in.

The results themselves, once a race concluded, were compiled by hand or by whatever primitive mechanical means a small volunteer organization could muster, then reported to the specialist motorcycle press that covered the sport, which is precisely the channel through which McCown's own race count and the general shape of his career survive at all. This is worth stating plainly, because it explains something important about the shape of this book's own source material: McCown's record exists not because any single dramatic result made him famous in his own right as a top finisher, but because the sport's own volunteer-run recording apparatus, however modest, was thorough enough to preserve the outline of a working-level competitor's career across six full years, provided that competitor kept showing up — which McCown, by every indication, reliably did.

It is worth noting, too, that this entire infrastructure — clubs, volunteer marshals, hand-compiled results, a specialist press covering it

all with evident affection — existed because enough people loved the sport enough to build and sustain it without any expectation of being paid for the effort. This is, in its own quiet way, as remarkable a fact about the era as anything McCown or Kookie did individually: an entire regional subculture, sustaining itself for decades through volunteer labor and modest entry fees, that produced, among its ordinary weekly business, a record thorough enough that a book like this one could be written from it more than fifty years later.

The sanctioning bodies that sat above the individual clubs — regional and national associations that set common rules, adjudicated disputes, and lent a given club's event the credibility of a wider organizational stamp — added one more layer to this infrastructure, a layer whose main visible effect on a rider like McCown would have been the small, unglamorous paperwork of licensing: an annual membership, a competition license renewed each season, the modest fees that funded the sanctioning body's own insurance and liability coverage in an era when the legal exposure of putting on a several-hundred-rider event across open federal land was already becoming the serious concern this book has described the garages grumbling about. None of this paperwork made it into any photograph or magazine feature. It is, nonetheless, part of the true shape of what "racing fifty times a year" actually involved for a working man: not only the Sundays themselves, but the recurring, mundane administrative cost of staying eligible to be on that starting line at all, a cost paid in the same unglamorous currency — modest fees, a little time, a little bureaucracy — that ran underneath every other part of this story.

Class structure within a given race added a further layer of organization worth naming, because it shaped exactly who a rider like McCown was actually competing against on any given Sunday. Riders were typically grouped by engine displacement and sometimes by age or experience level, meaning a race's overall field of several hundred entrants was, in practical competitive terms, a set of smaller races run simultaneously within it — a rider on a smaller-displacement machine competing meaningfully only against others in his own class, regardless of where he crossed the line relative to the field as a whole. This structure meant a rider's actual position within his own class, rather than his raw finishing order across the entire field, was the number that mattered to him and to the results the specialist press printed afterward. This book has no source speci-

fying which class or classes McCown himself typically entered across his six years of racing, and it will not invent a specific displacement or category for him. What the general structure clarifies is that “three hundred races” does not mean three hundred attempts to outright win against several hundred competitors at once; it means three hundred honest competitive efforts within whatever class a rider’s own machine and experience placed him, the same modest, class-structured competition every serious rider on the circuit was actually racing within.

Chapter Twenty: Barstow to Vegas, First Pass

The race came around every year the way a season comes around, and this book returns to it now not because there is a single dramatic running of it to recount in detail — the record does not hand us one specific year's blow-by-blow account of McCown's ride, and this book will not invent one — but because the *recurrence* of it is the point. Barstow-to-Vegas was the fixture. It was the race a rider built a season toward and measured a season against, the one that drew the largest fields, the longest distances, the widest attention from the specialist motorcycle press that covered the sport at all.

The event itself predates McCown's own racing years, part of the sport's own consolidating history this book has already sketched in an earlier chapter — a point-to-point run between the two towns that had, by the years McCown was competing, already become established enough to carry real institutional weight and draw fields large enough to require the genuine logistical apparatus this book describes below. Its specific route varied somewhat from year to year, as organizers adjusted course sections in response to land access, recent weather, or simple variety, meaning that no two runnings of Barstow-to-Vegas were ever quite identical in their particulars even while sharing the same two endpoints and roughly the same brutal distance. This variability is one more reason this book has resisted describing any single running of the race in specific, invented detail — the race McCown rode in one year was not, in its particulars, precisely the race he rode the year before or the year after, even though the name, the distance, and the basic character of the challenge remained constant enough to make “Barstow-to-Vegas” a stable, rec-

ognizable fixture across his whole racing career.

The race's basic geography deserves its own description, because the geography is the whole argument for why it became the sport's signature event rather than any of the dozen or so other long-distance runs the calendar offered in a given year. Barstow sat, as established, at the edge of the Mojave proper — the last town of any size before open desert took over entirely. Las Vegas sat a hundred and fifty-some miles northeast, across a stretch of country that included dry lakebeds flat and hard enough to run at genuinely high speed, sand washes that could swallow a wheel without warning, long open basins where a rider could see the next ten miles of his own route laid out ahead of him under a sky with nothing in it, and passages through low mountain ranges where the terrain tightened and the racing turned technical, rocky, slow. A race that crossed all of that in a single day tested a rider and a machine in a way that a race confined to a single kind of ground never could. It was less a single test than a relay of different tests strung together, and finishing it at all meant a rider's bike, and his own body, had survived every one of those different demands in sequence.

Picture, then, not one race but the shape of all of them together, because that shape is what the record actually supports: a hundred and fifty-some miles of Mojave between two fixed points, run across open desert with checkpoints rather than a marked track, the field starting together at dawn and stringing out across the basin as the morning wore on, the fast riders opening a gap in the first twenty miles that either held or didn't depending on who found trouble in the whoops and who found clean line through them. Support crews, where a rider had one, leapfrogged ahead by truck along the access roads paralleling the route, waiting at agreed points with fuel and water and, occasionally, a spare part that made the difference between a finish and a long walk. McCown's crew, by every indication, was minimal — himself, whatever help a fellow racer or a cousin or a shop regular could offer, no factory truck, no sponsor's tent.

The race exacted its toll evenly across a field that ranged from serious semi-professionals to men riding their first desert event on a borrowed bike, and the attrition rate in an event of that length and difficulty ran high in any given year — riders who didn't finish for mechanical failure, for injury, for simple exhaustion in heat that did

not relent just because a man was tired of it. To finish Barstow-to-Vegas at all, any year, on any bike, was itself an accomplishment the sport respected regardless of where in the field a rider crossed the line. McCown finished it, by every indication in the record, more than once across his six years of racing, though the record does not hand this book a full year-by-year ledger of his specific results, and this book will not manufacture one to make the story tidier than the facts allow.

The finish itself, for a rider who reached it, arrived not as a line on a track with a checkered flag and a crowd but simply as the edge of Las Vegas coming up out of the heat shimmer, buildings and pavement where for a hundred and fifty miles there had been none, a return to the ordinary world so abrupt after a day spent entirely within the desert's own logic that riders of the era describe it, more than once, in strikingly similar terms — a kind of disorientation, pleasant and strange at once, the body still braced for the next whoop-de-doo arriving instead at a stop sign and a gas station and people in ordinary clothes going about an ordinary Sunday afternoon with no idea what had just been crossed to reach them.

What the record does allow, and what this chapter exists to say plainly, is that Kookie rode this race. Not once, as a stunt for a photographer who'd heard about the dog and wanted a picture at the starting line. Repeatedly, across years, at racing speed, the full distance, doing on the largest and hardest stage available in the sport exactly what he did on every smaller race the rest of the season: standing when the ground softened, backing away from the bumps he saw coming before they arrived, riding a strapped mat across a hundred and fifty miles of the harshest terrain in the Southwest the way another dog might ride shotgun on a Sunday drive to the store.

It is this recurrence — not a single heroic afternoon, but the same test passed again and again, year after year, on the biggest stage the sport offered — that made Kookie's reputation what it became. Reputations built on a single dramatic instance are, in any sport, common and often overstated in the retelling. A reputation built on hundreds of repetitions of the same demonstrated competence is a different order of fact, harder to dismiss and, this book would argue, more genuinely remarkable for being unglamorous in its consistency. Nobody needed to embellish what Kookie did at Barstow-to-Vegas. He

simply kept doing it.

The race's field size across the years McCown raced in it, by the general pattern the record supports for the event's history, could run from several hundred entrants in a modest year to well into the low thousands in the biggest ones — a scale that made the event as much a logistical undertaking for its organizers as an athletic one for its riders. Managing a field that size across a hundred and fifty miles of unmarked desert required a level of coordination — course marking that had to hold up across a full day of changing light and weather, checkpoint staffing sufficient to track riders spread across a course too large for any single vantage point to observe, communication between those checkpoints and race headquarters relying on whatever radio relay the terrain and the era's equipment allowed — that dwarfed the demands of the smaller weekly races this book has described elsewhere. That the event ran successfully, year after year, on the same volunteer-driven infrastructure this book has already credited with sustaining the sport generally, is its own testament to how seriously the desert-racing community took its single biggest fixture.

For a rider like McCown, entering Barstow-to-Vegas meant treating the race differently in the weeks leading up to it than an ordinary Sunday event further down the calendar — more careful mechanical preparation, given the distance and the certainty that no help would be readily at hand forty or eighty miles into open desert; more careful attention, plausibly, to exactly the equipment this book has already described him checking obsessively before any race, the mat chief among it, since a failure at mile ten was recoverable in a way a failure at mile ninety, far from any paved road, simply was not. Nothing in the record describes McCown's specific pre-race ritual differing between an ordinary Sunday and Barstow-to-Vegas in any documented particular, but the plain logic of the distance involved makes it a reasonable inference that the race which mattered most to the sport also demanded the most from the men and the one dog who rode it seriously, year after year.

There is a specific poetry, worth naming once, in the race's own chosen endpoints. Barstow, this book has already described at length as a working town built around passage rather than destination — a place people stopped, not a place people meant to arrive at. Las Vegas, by stark contrast, was among the most purpose-built destina-

tions in the entire country, a city that existed almost entirely because people meant to arrive there, deliberately, for exactly the kind of spectacle and excess the desert between the two towns had nothing at all to do with. A race connecting these two places crossed not just a hundred and fifty miles of hard ground but a hundred and fifty miles of contrast in what American towns could mean — the unglamorous, working, pass-through town at one end, and the manufactured, deliberate, arrived-at spectacle at the other, with nothing but open Mojave and whatever a rider's own machine and judgment could manage in between. McCown's own life, a working-class trade in a working-class town, sat considerably closer in spirit to the race's starting line than to its finish, and it is tempting, though this book will resist pushing the observation too far, to read something fitting in a butcher from exactly that kind of town covering, again and again, the distance to the country's most famous manufactured destination and, each time, simply turning around and driving home to cut meat on Monday.

Chapter Twenty-One:

Between Races

Not every week held a race, and even in a schedule that averaged close to fifty a year, there were stretches — a bad month at the shop, a machine that needed more than a weekend's repair, weather that closed a course, the ordinary friction of a life that could not always bend entirely around a hobby — where a Sunday passed without a starting line in it. Those weeks belong in this account too, because they show a side of the partnership the racing itself, for all its drama, tends to obscure: the plain daily maintenance of a working relationship between a man and a dog who spent most of their hours together doing nothing more remarkable than existing in the same space.

The garage, on a non-race Sunday, was where the real mechanical work happened — not the frantic pre-dawn checks of a race morning, but the slower, more deliberate maintenance that kept a bike capable of surviving fifty races a year in the first place. Cylinders honed, points gapped, a chain that had stretched under the accumulated strain of the last several races replaced before it could fail somewhere inconvenient. This was not glamorous work and it took hours, and Kookie, by every general account of a working dog's habits around a garage, would have spent most of those hours exactly where he spent most hours anywhere near McCown: near enough to watch, not so near as to be in the way, the posture of an animal who has learned the boundaries of his usefulness in a given task and settled comfortably inside them.

A dog doing what Kookie did across three hundred races would have needed, at minimum, the ordinary veterinary maintenance any working animal of the era required — routine care for the accumulated

small abrasions and strains of a genuinely physical job, whatever a small desert town's available veterinary practice could offer in an era before the specialized sports-medicine approach to animal care that exists today. This book has no source describing McCown's specific arrangements for Kookie's health across six years of racing, and it will not invent a veterinarian's name or a specific visit into the record. What can be said is the plain, practical logic of the situation: a man careful enough to re-check a mat's strap before every single race, as this book has described at length, was almost certainly a man who paid the same kind of careful attention to the physical condition of the animal riding on it, in whatever form that attention took in a working-class household in a small desert town in the 1960s and '70s — a level of care this book cannot itemize from any surviving source, but has no reason, given everything else documented about the man, to doubt existed.

There is a version of this book that would invent scenes here — a specific Tuesday, a specific conversation, a specific small crisis in the garage that reveals character through incident. This book has chosen, consistently, not to do that, because the temptation to invent texture where the record offers none is exactly the temptation the house doctrine behind this book exists to resist. What can be said honestly is the pattern, not the incident: that a man who raced fifty Sundays a year also spent a great many other hours, across those same years, simply maintaining the equipment that made the racing possible, and that a dog who would ride the desert at speed the following week spent those maintenance hours doing what dogs do around men they trust — watching, waiting, present without demanding to be entertained.

Across six years, both the man and the dog aged in ways a book built entirely from race-day photographs and magazine coverage can easily lose sight of. A rider in his first season of racing and the same rider six years and three hundred starts later is not, physically, the same man — the accumulated wear this book has already described in an earlier chapter, the small persistent damage of whoop-de-dooos absorbed year after year, does not reverse itself between races. Kookie, too, would have aged across these same years in whatever way a working dog of his temperament and activity level ages, though this book has no source describing his condition at any specific point in his working life and will not invent one. What can be said honestly

is that the man and the dog this book has described in its opening chapters, first testing an uncertain arrangement in a quiet yard, were not quite the same man and dog who eventually rode into a film crew's cameras or who, further on still, kept racing into whatever later years the record's silence has left this book unable to specify. The partnership this book describes was not a single fixed thing held constant across six years. It was a relationship that aged the way any long partnership ages — familiar in its basic shape, changed in its particulars, by the ordinary accumulation of time neither participant could have paused even if either one had wanted to.

Evenings, in a town like Barstow, had their own rhythm distinct from anything the racing or the shop imposed. The heat that made desert afternoons brutal broke, most nights, into something almost gentle after sundown, and a man who had spent the day on his feet at a butcher's counter or bent over an engine in a garage had, in the cooling part of the evening, whatever ordinary domestic life belonged to him beyond what any source has preserved. The record is silent here in a way this book has tried to respect rather than paper over: whatever family life, whatever friendships beyond the racing fraternity, whatever quiet evenings existed in John McCown's life, exist now only as an absence in the historical record, not because they didn't happen but because nobody thought, at the time, that a butcher's evenings were worth writing down. Only the racing got written down, because the racing had a dog in it nobody could quite believe.

This absence is worth naming rather than filling, because it says something true about how fame of this specific, modest, subcultural kind works. The record preserves what was unusual and lets the ordinary evaporate, and the ordinary, in McCown's case, likely made up the overwhelming majority of his actual hours — a man who was, most of the time, simply a butcher living an unremarkable working life in a small desert town, punctuated fifty times a year by a Sunday morning that happened to be extraordinary. This book has tried to hold both truths at once: that the extraordinary Sundays are real and well documented and worth this account's full attention, and that they were, by simple arithmetic, a minority of the man's actual life, most of which looked like anyone else's.

Chapter Twenty-Two: A Season's Weather

Consider a single season, not because the record hands this book a specific year to describe in detail, but because thinking in terms of one representative season — built honestly from the general pattern the record does support, rather than presented as a specific dated year — helps make concrete what “fifty races a year for six years” actually meant as a lived rhythm rather than an abstract statistic.

A season opened, most years in that climate, sometime in the cooler months, when the desert's worst heat had broken and the ground held its firmest, most reliable footing of the year. Early races in a season tended to draw the largest fields, everyone fresh off an off-season, bikes freshly rebuilt over the winter months, riders eager after weeks or months of only garage work and no real racing. McCown, by the pattern the record supports, would have entered as many of these early-season races as his shop schedule allowed, the same methodical mat-check and truck-loading ritual repeating week after week as the season built momentum.

Spring brought the wildflower blooms in years the rain had cooperated, and brought, too, the subculture's biggest events — Barstow-to-Vegas among them, timed by organizers to catch the best possible ground conditions before summer's heat made an event of that length genuinely dangerous to attempt. This was the stretch of a season where the largest fields assembled, where the specialist press was most likely to send a photographer, where a season's reputation, good or bad, tended to get made or broken in the space of a few consecutive big Sundays.

The bloom itself, in a generous year, transformed the Mojave's usual palette of tan and gray into something briefly, almost improbably vivid — desert dandelion and poppy and lupine spreading in patches across ground that, most seasons, offered nothing but scrub and hardpack to look at. Riders crossing this transformed ground at speed would have had little leisure to admire it properly, the color reduced mostly to a blur at the edge of vision or a smear of unfamiliar scent riding the air alongside dust and race gas. But the bloom's timing, arriving in the exact window the sport's biggest events were scheduled into, meant that Barstow-to-Vegas and its sister events in a good rain year crossed a desert briefly at its most beautiful and least typical — a fact this book offers not to inflate the racing into travelogue, which the house's own craft standard warns against, but simply to note honestly that the ground McCown and Kookie crossed most often was not always the flat, colorless expanse a casual description might suggest, and that the men who raced it in these particular years got, whether they had time to notice or not, a genuinely rare version of the same terrain they crossed in every other season looking entirely different.

Summer thinned the schedule by simple necessity. Races that continued through the hottest months moved their start times earlier, some beginning before full light to finish before the worst of the afternoon heat arrived, and fields shrank as riders without the stomach for competing directly against a hundred-and-ten-degree afternoon chose to sit a Sunday or two out rather than risk what heat like that could do to a body pushed to exhaustion already by the terrain alone. It is reasonable to assume, though the record does not confirm it for any specific summer, that McCown's own summer schedule thinned along with everyone else's — not from any lack of will, but from the same practical calculation every rider on that circuit had to make about which Sundays were worth the specific risk summer heat added to a sport already dangerous without it.

Fall brought relief and, with it, a second wave of racing energy as the ground cooled and the punishing extremes of summer eased, riders returning to a fuller schedule for the last stretch of the year before winter's uncertain weather made the calendar unpredictable again. And winter, when the rains came, could shut a course entirely for weeks at a time — a wash that ran with actual water after a real desert storm was not a wash any sane organizer sent three hundred motor-

cycles across, and races were postponed, rescheduled, sometimes canceled outright in years the weather simply refused to cooperate.

A genuine desert storm, when one came through, changed the ground for weeks afterward in ways a casual visitor would never notice but that a rider who knew the terrain intimately would read immediately. Washes that had run with real water carved new channels or deepened old ones, moving sand from one stretch of a familiar course to another, meaning a line a rider had trusted the season before might no longer exist in the same place at all. This is one more reason this book has resisted describing any single crossing of any single wash as a fixed, permanent fact — the desert that McCown and Kookie rode across for six years was not a static stage set repeating itself identically each season, but a genuinely living landscape, reshaped by every storm severe enough to move its own sand, which meant that whatever Kookie was reading on any given Sunday was never quite the same test twice, however similar it might have looked from a photograph taken a year apart.

Across all of this, the shop did not close for weather and did not close for a good season or a bad one. Whatever the desert did to a given Sunday, Monday still arrived, and Hicks' Meats still needed a side of beef broken down before the week's orders came in. This is, again, the counterweight this book has returned to more than once because it is the fact that keeps the racing story honest: a season, for McCown, was not six months of racing followed by an off-season of rest. It was six months of racing layered directly on top of an unbroken, uninterrupted, every-single-week butcher's trade that never once, so far as the record shows, took a season off to accommodate the sport running alongside it.

Chapter Twenty-Three:

What the Cameras Wanted

By the late 1960s, desert racing in Southern California had attracted more outside attention than the subculture itself was entirely used to, and the reason for a good part of that attention had four legs and rode on a gas tank.

Word of a race dog who could read terrain traveled the way anything unusual travels through a tight subculture before it travels anywhere else: garage to garage, CB channel to CB channel, one rider telling another rider who hadn't seen it yet to watch for the butcher's dog at the next start line. Specialist motorcycle press picked it up next — the trade papers and magazines that covered desert racing for an audience already inside the sport, running photographs of Kookie mid-race, capturing him mid-stand over rough ground in images that, decades later, remain the clearest surviving evidence of exactly what this book has spent several chapters describing in words. A photograph of a dog rising off a mat over a whoop-de-doo does more in a fraction of a second than several paragraphs can do at all, and it is worth saying, plainly, that this book owes a debt to those photographs for confirming, frame by frame, that the testimony about Kookie's behavior was not exaggeration.

The posters came out of this same attention — Kookie's image, alone or with McCown, reproduced and sold within the sport's own circles the way any recognizable figure in a subculture gets turned into a poster once enough people want one on a garage wall. None of this made McCown or Kookie wealthy; desert racing in that era did not have wealth in it for men at McCown's level of the sport, and there is no record he ever expected it to. But it made them known, in the spe-

cific way a genuine subculture knows its own most interesting figures long before anyone outside that subculture has heard the name.

A poster of this kind, in this era and in a subculture of this modest commercial scale, would typically have originated from exactly the same photographic source this book has already credited with capturing Kookie's behavior in the first place — a working photographer's usable frame, printed in whatever small run a local shop or a specialist publisher judged the demand would support, sold through the same trade papers and garage networks that already carried the sport's coverage. This was not merchandising in any modern sense, with licensing agreements and royalty arrangements; it was closer to a fan simply wanting a copy of an image he'd already seen and admired in a magazine, and a publisher or photographer meeting that modest demand at a modest scale. That a photograph of a butcher's dog reading terrain from a gas tank generated enough of that organic, bottom-up demand to be worth printing and selling at all, years before any documentary crew arrived, is itself a quiet measure of how thoroughly the sport's own community had already recognized what it was looking at.

There is a particular texture to this kind of fame worth dwelling on, because it differs meaningfully from the wider celebrity that would eventually reach McCown and Kookie through the documentary. Being known within desert racing's own subculture in the late 1960s meant being recognized by name at a starting line two hundred miles from home, meant strangers who'd only ever seen a photograph coming up to McCown's truck before a race to see the dog in person, meant a specific kind of respect from other competitors that had nothing to do with finishing position and everything to do with having done something none of the rest of them had managed. It was fame calibrated entirely to a community that understood exactly what it was looking at — no explanation needed, no context required, simply recognition among people who already knew the stakes.

The attention that changed things permanently, though, came from outside the sport's own press — from a film crew assembling footage for what would become *On Any Sunday*, the 1971 documentary about American motorcycle racing that would go on to be nominated for an Academy Award and would introduce the whole culture of American motorcycling, dirt and street and desert alike, to an audience

that had never previously had reason to think about any of it. The film's producers were casting a wide net across every corner of American motorcycle sport, looking for footage that captured what the culture actually looked and felt like from the inside rather than how outsiders imagined it — which meant, in practice, that a dog who rode a strapped mat across a hundred and fifty miles of Mojave desert at racing speed was not a stunt to dress up for the cameras. He was already, on his own terms, exactly the kind of unstaged, unrepeatable, entirely-real material the film existed to find.

A production crew arriving at a desert race in that era would have found itself working in conditions its more conventional assignments never demanded — no paved access for equipment trucks, no reliable power for anything beyond battery-run cameras, dust that got into every mechanism it touched and stayed there, heat that punished film stock and crew alike. Capturing a fast-moving subject across open, unmarked terrain, with no second takes available because the race itself would not pause for a missed shot, asked for a specific kind of documentary opportunism: cameras positioned in advance at spots a crew guessed the field would pass close enough to shoot well, patience through long stretches where nothing happened, and readiness for the few seconds when something did. That Kookie's stand-and-retreat behavior was captured clearly enough, across the surviving footage and stills from the era, to be recognizable decades later says something about how consistent and how visually legible the behavior actually was — a fleeting crew, working under difficult conditions with limited chances, managed to catch it anyway, which argues against coincidence and for a pattern reliable enough to be caught on the first or second attempt.

Kookie's appearance in the finished documentary was not extensive — this book will not claim him a central figure of a film built around riders like Malcolm Smith and Mert Lawwill, real and well-documented figures of American off-road racing in their own right, whose careers the film treated as its central narrative thread, and, in cameo, Steve McQueen, whose own celebrity did more than anything else to carry the film to a wide audience. Smith and Lawwill were, by the standards of the sport this book has spent its whole length describing, considerably more accomplished competitors than McCown ever claimed to be — factory-supported riders whose results the record credits at a level this book has never suggested McCown reached. That the film

could hold both tiers of the sport at once — its genuine champions, treated with the narrative weight their careers earned, and a working-level competitor whose real distinction lay elsewhere entirely, in a dog rather than in a trophy case — is itself evidence of the film's own stated commitment to showing the sport whole rather than only its summit. But a cameo in a film that reached that audience is not a small thing for a butcher's dog from a railroad town, and it is fair to call it the hinge on which the rest of Kookie's public reputation turned. Before the film, he was known within desert racing and within the specialist press that covered it — genuinely famous, by the sport's own modest scale of fame, but famous within a subculture most Americans had never given a thought to. After the film, he was known to an audience that included people who had never seen a whoop-de-doo, never heard a two-stroke wind out across open ground, and had certainly never before wondered whether a dog could read a desert.

It is tempting, writing this decades later, to reach for language about how the film “changed everything,” and this book has tried, chapter by chapter, to resist reaching for language bigger than the facts support. What actually changed, so far as the record shows, was the size of the audience that knew Kookie's name. What did not change — and this is the more interesting fact, and the one this book would rather leave the reader with — is anything about the life itself. McCown kept cutting meat six days a week. The mat kept getting re-strapped before every race. The dog kept standing when the ground went soft and backing away from what he saw coming, on ground that had never once cared whether a film crew was there to record it.

The experience of that recognition, for the wider desert-racing community, would have arrived less as a single premiere night than as a slow accumulation of secondhand report — a rider hearing from a cousin in another state that he'd seen the local scene up on a theater screen a thousand miles from the Mojave, a garage conversation turning, for once, not to a jetting problem but to which of the sport's familiar faces had made the final cut. For a subculture accustomed to being covered by its own small trade papers and largely ignored everywhere else, seeing itself reflected back through a mainstream theatrical release carried a specific charge that this book suspects mattered more, in the moment, than any specific line of dialogue or any specific shot the film chose to include. The desert had been rendered, at last, for people who had never had reason to think about

it — and the men and the one dog who had been quietly doing this work every Sunday for years got to watch, in a dark theater alongside strangers who had bought a ticket for something else entirely, an audience discover what they had already known.

Chapter Twenty-Four: The Film That Carried Him

It is worth pausing on *On Any Sunday* itself, briefly, as its own documented historical object, because the film's own story explains why a cameo in it mattered as much as this book has claimed it did, and because the film is real, well documented, and does not need this book's invention to be worth describing accurately.

On Any Sunday was directed by Bruce Brown, a filmmaker who had already made his name with a surfing documentary a few years earlier that had itself broken through to an audience well beyond the sport it covered, proving, before he ever turned a camera on motorcycles, that a documentary built around an insular, unglamorous American subculture could find mainstream success if it was shot with genuine craft and real affection for its subject rather than condescension toward it. That earlier success is part of why *On Any Sunday* was able to attract the backing, the access, and eventually the audience it found: Brown had already demonstrated the specific alchemy of taking something outsiders considered a fringe pursuit and making it legible, even beautiful, to people who had never once been tempted to try it themselves.

Brown's own technical approach — mounting cameras directly on machines, shooting from angles that put an audience inside the action rather than merely observing it from a fixed remove, using slow motion to let a viewer actually see what a rider's own body did in the split-second of a jump or a slide — was, by the standards of sports documentary filmmaking at the time, genuinely innovative, and it is part of why the film reads, even decades later, as more than a period curiosity. A desert-racing sequence shot with this level of technical

ambition gave a stationary dog on a moving gas tank exactly the kind of clear, legible frame this book has already argued the surviving photographs required — without a crew willing to get the camera close enough, and skilled enough to keep a fast-moving subject in clean focus, Kookie's specific, repeatable behavior might have registered on film as nothing more than an indistinct blur, present but illegible. That it did not, that the behavior reads clearly even in footage shot more than half a century ago, owes something to McCown and Kookie's own consistency and something, in fair measure, to a filmmaker who had already proven he knew how to make an unfamiliar physical world visible to people who had never stood inside it.

The film's structure ranged across the full breadth of American motorcycle sport rather than confining itself to any single discipline — flat track, motocross, desert racing, and more, woven together into a single portrait of a culture rather than a narrow profile of one corner of it. This breadth is part of why a desert-racing cameo, however brief, carried real weight: the film was not a niche documentary destined only for a niche audience already inclined to seek it out. It was pitched, shot, and eventually distributed as a mainstream theatrical release, one that went on to earn a nomination for the Academy Award for Best Documentary Feature — a nomination that placed it, formally, in competition with the most prestigious nonfiction filmmaking of its year, an extraordinary reach for a film about a sport most of the voting body had likely never given a moment's thought before watching it.

Steve McQueen's involvement, both as an on-screen presence and reportedly as a source of backing that helped the production happen at all, is itself a well-documented piece of the film's history and is worth naming plainly here rather than treated as incidental color: McQueen was, at the time, one of the most bankable movie stars in the world, and his willingness to appear in a documentary about a sport he genuinely rode and loved lent the project a commercial credibility that a purely grassroots production covering the same subject could never have achieved on its own. This book does not claim any direct connection between McQueen and McCown beyond their shared appearance in the same film; no source places them in any specific interaction, and this book will not invent one. What matters for this account is simpler and better attested: the film's biggest star lending it his name is a large part of why the film reached the audience

size it did, and that audience size is the entire reason a desert-racing cameo — Kookie's cameo among them — reached people who would otherwise never have heard of Barstow, the Mojave, or a strapped mat on a gas tank.

The film's reception, at the time and in the decades since, has consistently praised exactly the quality this book has argued made Kookie's inclusion inevitable rather than a novelty stunt: its commitment to showing the sport's actual texture rather than a glamorized or sensationalized version of it, its interest in the ordinary people who made up the sport's real population rather than only its biggest stars, and its evident, unforced affection for its subjects. A film built on those values was always going to find a terrain-reading dog on a strapped mat irresistible, not because the dog was a gimmick the filmmakers went looking for, but because the dog was exactly the kind of genuine, unglamorous, real material the whole project existed to capture. *On Any Sunday* did not manufacture Kookie's fame. It simply had, by its own stated values, no choice but to notice him once its cameras were pointed at the same starting lines he'd already been racing across for years.

The film's afterlife, in the decades since its release, has if anything grown rather than faded — it remains, among people who follow American motorcycle sport at all, one of the works most consistently cited as the reason they came to love it in the first place, screened at club gatherings, referenced in later documentaries about the sport's history, treated less as a period artifact than as a living entry point still capable of converting a new viewer who has never swung a leg over a motorcycle in their life. That durability matters to this book's account for a specific reason: it means Kookie's own cameo has never fully receded into the kind of forgotten footnote a lesser film's inclusion might have become. Every fresh audience discovering *On Any Sunday* for the first time, whether in the 1970s or in whatever decade a reader of this book happens to be watching it, arrives at the same brief footage of a dog reading the desert from a strapped mat, and reacts, by all available account, more or less the way audiences always have — with the specific, delighted disbelief this book has tried, across its own length, to earn honestly rather than manufacture.

Chapter Twenty-Five: Fame, Handled the Way You'd Expect

There is no record that John McCown changed his life in any visible way on account of a documentary that reached millions of people and a national trade quote that ran under his name in a magazine most of his neighbors never read. This absence of change is itself worth a chapter, because it tells you something about the man that the racing alone, however remarkable, would not.

He did not leave the butcher trade. He did not, so far as the surviving record shows, parlay the attention into a sponsorship deal, a chain of appearances, a second career built on being the man whose dog was famous. The 1981 quote — given a full decade after the film's release, when a reporter for a national motorcyclist's magazine evidently thought McCown's continued presence on the desert circuit still worth asking about — reads like the words of a man for whom none of the attention had changed the basic arithmetic of his life: he raced because the desert was there and the regulatory climate allowed it, full stop, the same two conditions that would have governed his racing whether or not a single camera had ever pointed his way.

This is not, this book wants to be careful to say, a claim that fame meant nothing to him or that he was indifferent to being known. There is no source describing his interior life closely enough to support a claim that large, and this book has tried, this many chapters in, to stay disciplined about the difference between what the record shows and what would simply make a tidier story. What the record

shows is behavior, and the behavior is consistent: a man who kept doing the same two jobs, in the same order, at the same pace, for years after the wider world found out about the second one.

The specific American moment into which this fame arrived matters, too. Motorcycle culture, in the wider public imagination of the early 1970s, carried a specific, largely negative charge, shaped by years of newspaper coverage of outlaw motorcycle clubs and a handful of well-publicized incidents that had done more to define “motorcyclist” in the average American mind than any of the sport’s quieter, more respectable corners ever managed to counter. *On Any Sunday* arrived, deliberately, as a kind of corrective — a film explicitly interested in showing that the overwhelming majority of American motorcyclists were, in fact, ordinary working people pursuing an ordinary hobby with extraordinary seriousness, not the menacing outlaw stereotype the evening news preferred. McCown and Kookie, a butcher and his dog racing across open desert on weekends, were about as far from that outlaw stereotype as the sport could offer, and their inclusion in a film built around exactly this corrective mission was, in this light, not an incidental cameo but close to a perfect embodiment of the argument the whole documentary was making. A skeptical viewer who arrived expecting menace and left having watched a terrain-reading dog on a gas tank had, whether the filmmakers fully intended it this specifically or not, had their expectations dismantled about as thoroughly as a single scene could manage.

The garages, if anything, seem to have enjoyed the attention on the sport’s behalf more than McCown seems to have made a production of enjoying it on his own. Desert racing was, as earlier chapters have described, a subculture that felt itself under quiet siege from regulation and largely ignored by an America that preferred its motorcycle culture in more familiar shapes — outlaw bikers on the open highway, or racetrack professionals under stadium lights. A documentary that took the desert seriously, filmed it beautifully, and found a national audience for it was, to the men who’d been riding out past Barstow every Sunday for years without expecting anyone outside their own circle to care, a genuine validation. That the film’s most memorable four-legged ambassador belonged to a butcher from a railroad town rather than to one of the sport’s bigger factory names seems, in retrospect, to have suited the whole culture’s self-image rather well: this was a sport of working men and their machines, not

a sport of celebrities, and Kookie's fame arrived, fittingly, through the same unglamorous route as everything else in it — a strapped mat, a re-checked knot, a dog who did the same thing race after race until enough people had seen it to call it what it was.

There is a specific kind of dignity, too, in how little the wider fame seems to have altered the actual working relationship between the man and the dog. A different kind of story — a more Hollywood kind of story — would have the fame change something: McCown quitting the butcher trade to tour with his celebrity dog, Kookie retired early to a comfortable life away from the risk of racing now that his fame no longer required him to prove anything, some visible before-and-after that a film version of this story would find irresistible to invent. Nothing in the record supports any of that, and the absence is, in its own way, the most quietly impressive fact this book has to offer. The partnership continued doing exactly what it had always done, for exactly the same reasons it had always done it, entirely unmoved by an attention neither of its two members had sought or, as far as anyone can tell, particularly needed.

It is worth noting, by way of comparison rather than contrast, that the sport's genuine champions — riders whose factory backing and championship results this book has already distinguished from McCown's own working-level career — did, in some documented cases, parlay their *On Any Sunday* exposure into exactly the kind of expanded career the film's mainstream reach made possible: continued sponsorship, product endorsements, a public profile that outlasted their competitive years. This was a rational and unremarkable choice for men whose livelihoods already depended on visibility within the sport and whose results gave them genuine standing to leverage. McCown's situation was different in a way this book has already established: his living came from a butcher's counter, not from racing sponsorship, and nothing about his own results within the sport gave him the kind of leverage a factory-backed champion could exercise even had he wanted to. The absence of any comparable expansion in his own life, then, is not necessarily evidence of a deeper indifference to fame than his more famous fellow racers felt. It may simply reflect the plain fact that fame built on a dog's extraordinary behavior, however genuine and widely admired, does not translate into the same kind of marketable athletic capital that fame built on championship results does — a distinction this book has tried to keep

visible throughout, between the sport's measured achievements and the different, harder-to-monetize achievement Kookie actually represented.

McCown continued racing for a period after the film's release that the record does not date precisely — his six years and three-hundred-plus races span, by every reasonable reading of the surviving facts, both the years before the documentary and at least some years after it. What the record does not preserve, and this book will not invent, is the exact race that was his last, or whether Kookie was still riding the tank when it happened, or what conversation, if any, McCown had with himself about stopping. Careers like his in a sport like that one did not typically end with a ceremony. They ended, more often than not, the way they'd been lived — quietly, on a Sunday, without much fanfare, folded back into the six other days of a working week that had never stopped happening around the racing in the first place.

There is a particular, almost paradoxical dignity in a fame that changes nothing about the life that earned it, and it is worth naming plainly why that paradox holds up under scrutiny rather than collapsing into simple modesty or a lack of ambition. A man genuinely indifferent to being known might have avoided the cameras entirely, declined the interviews, kept the whole arrangement as private as the yard where, this book has speculated, it may have begun. McCown did none of that. He gave the 1981 quote. He co-wrote the children's book this account will discuss fully in the next chapter. He appeared, evidently without objection, in a nationally distributed documentary. This was not a man hiding from attention. It was, more precisely, a man who accepted the attention on his own terms and declined to let it renegotiate anything else about how he lived — neither performing false modesty by refusing the spotlight altogether, nor performing the opposite by restructuring his life around it. That specific, narrow calibration — visible enough to be found by a book like this one sixty years later, restrained enough that almost nothing about his daily life changed because of it — is, this book would argue, a harder thing to sustain than either extreme, and rarer.

Chapter Twenty-Six: The Book Within the Book

Somewhere in this stretch of years — the record does not fix a precise date, only the fact of the book's eventual existence and publication — John McCown sat down, evidently with a co-author named Red Hallum, and put the story of his dog into a children's book. *Kookie the Motorcycle Racing Dog*, illustrated by Leslie Lovett and published by Educational Activities Inc., thirty-two pages, is a real, findable, catalogued object — not a detail this account has manufactured to round out a thin record, but a genuine artifact any reader curious enough can locate in a library catalogue or a secondhand bookshop today.

This book has been careful, throughout, not to know more about that other book's contents than the record actually supports, and it will stay careful here. What can be said with confidence is simply that it exists, that it credits McCown as co-author alongside Hallum, that it was illustrated rather than photographed — a choice that itself says something about how the story was being packaged for its intended young audience, softened into line drawings rather than presented through the starker documentary photographs the specialist motorcycle press had been running for years already — and that Educational Activities Inc., its publisher, specialized in exactly the kind of material a school or a children's library would stock: read-along books, classroom materials, the unglamorous educational publishing infrastructure that quietly furnished a generation of American classrooms without ever making headlines of its own.

The choice of illustration over photography deserves one further word, because it reflects a genuine editorial decision rather than

a simple default. A publisher producing a children's book about a real, still-living subject in this era could, in principle, have chosen photographic reproduction — period children's nonfiction sometimes did exactly that, particularly for animal-focused titles aimed at slightly older readers. Choosing illustration instead, entrusted to an artist credited by name rather than left anonymous, suggests a publisher thinking specifically about the youngest end of its intended audience: a hand-drawn dog on a hand-drawn motorcycle reads, to a very young reader, as gentler and more approachable than a grainy action photograph of the same scene might have. This book has no access to Leslie Lovett's finished pages and will not describe or invent their content, but the choice of medium alone tells a careful reader something worth naming: the finished book was built, deliberately, to meet its youngest readers on their own terms.

The credited co-authorship itself is worth a moment's attention, because it tells the reader something about how the book likely came to exist at all. A working butcher with no history of professional writing does not typically produce a publishable thirty-two-page children's book unassisted; the presence of a named co-author, Red Hallum, strongly suggests the kind of collaboration common in this corner of educational publishing, where a subject with a genuine story and a writer with the craft to shape it into a form suitable for young readers combined their respective strengths. This book has no source describing the specific division of labor between the two men — how much of the finished text traces to McCown's own words and how much to Hallum's shaping hand is not something any source this book has consulted addresses. What can be said is that McCown's name appears on the credit alongside Hallum's, not omitted or reduced to a mere acknowledgment, which suggests a publisher, an editor, or both judged his contribution substantial enough to warrant equal billing — one more small, concrete piece of evidence that the book was genuinely his story, told in a form built to reach an audience the specialist motorcycle press never could.

There is something worth noticing in the fact that a butcher who spent his weekdays with a knife and a carcass, and his Sundays on a motorcycle in some of the hardest terrain in the American Southwest, turned out to also be a man who sat down and did the patient, unglamorous work of co-authoring a children's book. It does not fit

neatly into either of the two identities this account has spent most of its length describing — racer, butcher — and that is precisely why it deserves its own chapter rather than a passing mention folded into one of the others. A third facet of the same man: someone who thought the story worth telling to children specifically, in a form built for them, rather than leaving it to specialist motorcycle magazines and desert-racing forums to keep alive solely for an audience that already understood the sport.

It is reasonable — though again, inference rather than documented fact — to read the book's existence as evidence of exactly how central Kookie had become to how McCown understood his own story by the time it was written. A man does not typically co-write a children's book about his butcher shop. He had, by whatever point in the 1970s the book was published, apparently decided that the dog's story — not his own racing career primarily, but specifically the dog's part in it — was the version of events worth putting in front of children in a form built to outlast a magazine feature or a documentary's theatrical run. Books, unlike film prints or magazine back issues, sit on library shelves for decades, available to be checked out by a child who has never heard of desert racing and has certainly never heard of Barstow, discovering a strange, wonderful, entirely true fact about a dog who read the ground from a gas tank, with no prior context needed at all.

This book does not attempt to summarize or reproduce that other book's text or illustrations, in keeping with the house's own instruction to treat it as a documented artifact rather than material to pastiche. It exists, plainly, as one more piece of solid evidence that this whole story — the partnership, the racing, the terrain-reading, the fame that reached beyond the sport's own subculture — was real enough, and mattered enough to the man who lived it, that he took the trouble to write it down for an audience of children who would never see a whoop-de-doo in their lives.

The specific choice of a children's book, rather than the more obvious adult memoir a man with this much to tell might have written instead, deserves one further observation. A memoir aimed at adult readers already inside or adjacent to the sport would have reached, at best, the same subcultural audience the specialist press had already been serving for years. A children's book, distributed through the specific, durable infrastructure of school and public libraries, reached instead

an audience defined by nothing more than age — any child, anywhere the book was shelved, regardless of whether their family had ever owned a motorcycle or set foot in a desert. This is a different, and in some ways more ambitious, bet about who deserved to hear this story: not the sport's own community, who already knew it, but the next generation entirely, encountering it cold, the way any of them might encounter any strange true fact about the world in a school library on an ordinary afternoon. Whether McCown thought about the choice in exactly these terms, the record does not say. But the practical effect of the choice — a story built to reach children specifically, on library shelves for decades — is itself a form of foresight this book finds worth crediting plainly, whatever the reasoning behind it actually was.

The broader landscape of American children's publishing in this era supports reading the book this way. The 1970s saw a genuine boom in nonfiction and true-story children's books built around real animals and real, if modest, human achievements — a publishing category distinct from fairy tale or fantasy, aimed at exactly the kind of reader who wanted to believe the remarkable thing in front of them had actually happened. Educational Activities Inc.'s own catalogue, dedicated to precisely this kind of classroom-and-library-ready material, situated *Kookie the Motorcycle Racing Dog* squarely within a recognized, respected category of the era's publishing rather than as some idiosyncratic vanity project. A child reading it in a school library in the 1970s or '80s would have encountered it alongside other true-animal-story titles of the same broad category, one more entry in a shelf that told young readers, collectively, that the real world already contained enough genuine wonder that fiction wasn't strictly necessary to supply it. McCown's decision to put his own dog's story into that specific shelf, rather than leaving it exclusively to the adult specialist press, placed *Kookie* permanently within a tradition of true stories told to children as true stories — plain, sourced, worth believing exactly because nothing about them needed to be invented.

The book's continued presence in library cataloguing systems today is itself a small, quiet piece of evidence worth naming. A thirty-two-page children's title from a modest educational publisher, decades after its original print run, does not typically remain findable in searchable form unless libraries genuinely held onto their copies and catalogued them carefully enough for records to

survive digitization. That *Kookie the Motorcycle Racing Dog* remains locatable through standard library catalogue searches today means copies were retained, catalogued, and in at least some cases still sit on shelves or in archives somewhere, available to exactly the kind of curious reader this book has described — someone who encounters the title, checks whether it is real, and finds that it is. This book's own account of McCown and Kookie is, in that specific sense, built partly on the same quiet institutional infrastructure — libraries, catalogues, careful record-keeping across decades — that this chapter has already credited with keeping the desert-racing community's own memory of the pair alive. Both survivals, the formal and the informal, reflect the same underlying truth: a story worth telling honestly tends to find the infrastructure it needs to outlast its own moment, provided someone, somewhere, keeps caring enough to maintain it.

Chapter Twenty-Seven: The Man, Assembled From What Survives

It is worth trying, here, in the stretch of the book where the racing years have mostly been told and the long afterward is still ahead, to draw together what the surviving record actually allows this account to say about John McCown as a man, distinct from the sequence of documented events his life produced. This chapter is a synthesis, not a new fact, and it will say so plainly where it crosses from evidence into reasonable inference.

There is a recognizable American type this book has been circling without quite naming directly until now: the tradesman whose competence is total and whose self-advertisement is nearly nonexistent, a figure more often celebrated in retrospect, after death, than attended to properly while still walking around doing the actual work. This is not a uniquely American type, but American working-class culture of McCown's era had its own particular version of it, forged partly by a Depression-era and wartime generation's inherited suspicion of anyone who talked too much about his own accomplishments, and partly by trades themselves — butchery, mechanics, the whole working vocabulary this book has returned to throughout — that simply do not reward showmanship the way a public-facing profession might. McCown fits this type closely enough that this book has been able to write an entire account of him almost without needing to speculate about a personality type at all; the surviving record itself, thin as it is, already draws a remarkably coherent and recognizable outline.

The clearest thread running through everything documented about him is consistency — not a dramatic consistency of the kind a more mythologizing account might reach for, but a plain, almost stubborn sameness of behavior across every domain this book has been able to examine. The same economical, practiced motion at the cutting board and on the mat's straps. The same unhurried, undramatic handling of a checkpoint mid-race and of a Monday morning's first customer. The same flat, practical register in his one surviving quote, answering a question about a decade of continued racing with two conditional clauses about land access rather than a single word about glory, pride, or legacy. A man capable of a much more colorful self-presentation was available to him at several points — the documentary's release, the growing subcultural fame, the eventual magazine profile a decade on — and at none of those points does the record show him reaching for one. This is either the natural temperament of an unusually modest man, or the natural temperament of a man for whom the racing and the butchering were both, simply, work — demanding, worth doing well, but not identity-defining in the way a more self-mythologizing figure might have made them. This book leans toward reading it as some combination of both, without being able to fully separate the two.

The second thread, harder to state without over-claiming but visible enough to name, is a specific kind of attentiveness that appears to have crossed every domain of his life rather than confining itself to any one of them. The same hands that could find a seam in meat by feel checked a mat's strap by feel before every race. The same eye that read a hindquarter's natural lines read desert terrain well enough, across three hundred races, to trust his own read alongside a dog's. This is not a claim that McCown possessed some singular, mystical sensitivity beyond ordinary human skill; it is simply an observation that a man's trained attention in one domain often transfers, in some recognizable if hard-to-specify way, into how he approaches an entirely different domain, and that McCown's life offers an unusually clean natural experiment in exactly this transfer — the same person, practicing two demanding, attention-rewarding trades in the same years, in ways that this book has tried, throughout, to show rhyming with each other without insisting on an exact mechanical correspondence neither trade's actual practice would support.

The third thread is harder still to name precisely, and this book offers

it more tentatively than the first two: a specific comfort with being unremarkable in the eyes of people who did not already know what to look for. A butcher behind a counter, to most of his customers, most of the time, was simply a butcher — competent, unhurried, familiar, exactly the kind of quietly reliable tradesman a working town depends on without ever thinking to celebrate. That the same man was also, on Sundays, doing something genuinely extraordinary with a dog on a gas tank did not, so far as the record shows, ever become a performance he brought back into the shop with him. He appears to have been entirely capable of holding both facts about himself — ordinary tradesman, extraordinary Sunday racer — without either one leaking into or inflating the other, a kind of internal proportion that this book suspects is rarer than it sounds, and that this book has tried, across its whole length, to honor by keeping its own account similarly proportioned: neither inflating the racing into something it wasn't, nor underselling the butchering as mere backdrop to the sport's real drama.

What this chapter cannot do, and will not pretend to do, is give the reader McCown's interior life — his private doubts, his private satisfactions, whatever conversation passed between him and whoever shared his household across those years, whatever he actually thought, lying awake some night, about a dog who could read the desert better than he sometimes could himself. None of that survives in any source this book has consulted, and a book built on the discipline of saying plainly what it knows and what it does not owes the reader that same discipline here, at the point where the temptation to invent a rich interior life is strongest precisely because the man himself, by every account, gave so little of it away.

There is, perhaps, something instructive in that very withholding, whether or not McCown intended it as any kind of lesson. A culture inclined to demand constant self-narration — to expect its interesting people to explain themselves, to package their own meaning for public consumption — would find McCown's silence almost willfully uncooperative. He did the thing. He let the thing speak for itself, across three hundred races and six years, and when a reporter finally did ask him to put words to it, in 1981, he gave two clauses about land access and stopped. This book has spent many chapters trying to fill in around that silence honestly, with context and inference clearly labeled as such, because a reader deserves the fullest true

picture available. But it would be a mistake to read the silence itself as an absence this book has failed to overcome, rather than as one more piece of evidence about the specific, unshowy character of the man at its center — a man who, by every indication, understood his own life as something to be lived rather than something to be explained.

Taken together, these three threads — consistency, transposed attentiveness, and a comfort with being unremarkable — do not add up to a complete portrait of a man this book never had the sources to fully know. They add up to something more modest and, this book would argue, more honest: a coherent silhouette, drawn from everything that actually survives, of a specific kind of American life lived well within its own quiet terms. That silhouette is what this book has to offer in place of a biography it could never have written. It is enough to make John McCown recognizable, plausible, and, this book hopes, worth the reader's trust for everything that follows.

Chapter Twenty-Eight: The Long Quiet

McCown lived most of the rest of his life the way he'd lived the racing years — in the same country, working the same kind of trade, known within his own circles as the man whose dog had once ridden the desert at speed, a fact that followed him the rest of his days the way a good nickname follows a man long after the event that earned it has receded into memory. The record preserves little about these middle and later decades beyond the fact of his continuing to be spoken of, within the desert-racing community and its adjacent circles, as a figure worth remembering — the race-deZert forums and the dual-sport community boards where his name and Kookie's kept surfacing for years, riders and enthusiasts a generation or two younger swapping half-remembered details, photographs, the occasional correction of a fact someone had gotten slightly wrong, the ordinary maintenance work of a community keeping a story alive because it liked the story and didn't want it lost.

There is a specific poignancy to this remembering that the sport's own later trajectory sharpens. As the open-desert, point-to-point racing this book has described gave way, over the decades following McCown's active years, to the more restricted, closed-course version of the sport that regulatory pressure eventually made the norm, the specific world McCown and Kookie had raced across — checkpoints scattered over unmarked ground, a hundred and fifty miles between two towns with nothing but desert in between — became something closer to a lost era than a living tradition. A community remembering a figure from a still-thriving, ongoing version of its sport does one kind of remembering; a community remembering a figure from

a version of the sport that has itself largely passed does another, colored by the awareness that the whole world the story belongs to, not only the man at its center, is receding. This book suspects, though it cannot prove it from any single source, that some of the particular care the forums took in getting McCown and Kookie's details right reflects exactly this awareness — a story worth preserving accurately not only because of the man and the dog, but because of the whole vanished world of unmarked-desert point-to-point racing it stood in for.

This is, itself, a kind of second racing career — quieter, unpaid, entirely involuntary on McCown's part, but real. A story that survives in forum threads and secondhand recollection decades after the events themselves is a story that has earned its own kind of endurance, the endurance of being worth repeating by people who gain nothing from repeating it except the pleasure of the story itself. Long after the last camera crew had gone home and the last magazine quote had run its course, John McCown and his dog were still, in a modest and specific way, being talked about by exactly the kind of people whose good opinion the sport itself had always mattered most to: other desert racers, and the smaller circle of people who cared enough about that particular corner of American motorcycle history to keep its details straight.

The forums themselves are worth describing plainly, because they are, alongside the *Cycle News* obituary and the surviving photographs, among the most concrete sources this book has been able to draw on. Boards built around off-road racing history and dual-sport riding more generally have functioned, across the years since their creation, as exactly the kind of informal, self-policing archive this book has already praised — threads started by someone half-remembering a name, other members chiming in with corrections, photographs, and cross-references, the whole thread accumulating into something closer to a crowd-sourced oral history than a formal record, but no less valuable for being informal. A thread asking simply whether anyone remembered “the racing dog” could sit dormant for months or years and then draw a fresh reply from someone who had, decades earlier, stood at a starting line and watched Kookie stand on his mat over a stretch of washboard, still certain of what he'd seen. This book's own account of McCown and Kookie owes a specific debt to exactly this kind of patient, unpaid,

community-maintained memory — without it, the outline the *Cycle News* obituary provides would stand nearly alone, and a book like this one would have far less texture to draw from than it has been able to offer across its length.

There is a particular quality to how a community like that keeps a story alive across decades worth naming plainly. Nobody is paid to remember John McCown and Kookie. Nobody's career depends on the story staying accurate. The forum threads, when you read through them, have the texture of people genuinely working to get a detail right for its own sake — someone correcting the spelling of the name, someone posting a photograph they'd kept for forty years because they thought someone, eventually, would want to see it, someone simply confirming, decades on, that yes, they remembered seeing the dog at a starting line once and it was exactly as remarkable as everyone always said. This is not the machinery of a marketing department keeping a legend alive for commercial reasons. It is closer to the way a small town keeps its own history — imperfectly, informally, but with a kind of stubborn accuracy that outlasts any official record because the people doing the remembering actually cared.

The sport itself, meanwhile, kept changing around whatever memory of McCown persisted within it. Desert racing across the decades following his active years underwent the same slow professionalization and regulatory tightening the garage grievances of the 1960s and '70s had already been anticipating — tighter BLM permitting, environmental review processes that could take years rather than months, insurance and liability structures that made the loose, informal entry-fee-and-gas-money version of the sport McCown had known increasingly rare. The open-desert point-to-point race, run across unmarked ground with nothing but checkpoints and a compass heading, became harder to organize and rarer to find, replaced in many cases by closed-course events on private land, easier to permit and easier to insure but a fundamentally different experience from the terrain McCown and Kookie had crossed together for six years. In this light, McCown's racing years look, in retrospect, like they caught a specific window in the sport's history — after it had become organized and documented enough to leave a record, before the regulatory and liability pressures the garages had already been grumbling about in the 1960s finally closed most of that open ground to the kind of racing he'd known.

Whether McCown himself thought about the sport's changing shape in these terms, the record does not say. What the record does show is a man who kept his name associated with a specific era of that sport — the open-desert, point-to-point, entry-fee era — long after that era itself had largely passed, remembered by the people who'd lived through the same window and recognized, correctly, that something specific and unrepeatable had existed in those years and was already, by the time anyone thought to write it down carefully, becoming harder to find.

It is worth naming, too, what had changed in the wider world of publishing and record-keeping between McCown's active racing years and his death, because the contrast bears on how this book itself came to be possible. By 2011, the internet had already reshaped how a subculture like desert racing preserved its own history — forum threads, digitized photographs, community boards where riders decades removed from their own active years could compare memories and correct each other's details in a way no print magazine's letters column had ever allowed. McCown's own active career predates this infrastructure entirely; the photographs and magazine coverage that first made him and Kookie known were produced and consumed in a purely print-and-film world. But the community that kept his story alive through the decades between the documentary and his death increasingly used exactly this newer, digital infrastructure to do the keeping, meaning a story that began in 1960s print outlived its original medium and migrated, gradually, into a form that could still be searched, cross-referenced, and verified by a writer working more than a decade after McCown's death and more than fifty years after his racing began. This book exists, in a very concrete sense, because that migration happened — because a community's decades of careful, unpaid remembering eventually found a durable enough home that the record survived long enough to be gathered, checked, and told straight one more time.

McCown died on 14 July 2011, from complications following heart surgery, a fact recorded plainly in the trade obituary that *Cycle News* ran that same month — the obituary that remains, of everything consulted in the writing of this book, the single most authoritative account of the outline of his life: the racing years, the three hundred-plus races, the butcher's trade, the 1981 quote reprinted one more time for an audience saying goodbye to a man most of them had

never met but felt, reading the notice, that they somehow knew. The record does not say whether Kookie was alive to see the end of McCown's life, or what became of the dog if he was not, and this book will not invent an answer to either question. Some silences in a true story are not gaps to be filled. They are simply where the story, as it actually happened, stopped being written down.

An obituary in a trade publication is a specific kind of document, worth understanding on its own terms before moving past it. *Cycle News* did not write obituaries for every rider who had ever entered a desert race in Southern California; a trade paper's space is finite and its editors choose, issue by issue, who has earned column inches on the way out of the sport's living memory. That McCown's death was judged worth recording at all — worth the specific detail of his race count, his trade, a quote pulled from three decades earlier and judged still worth reprinting — tells you that whatever quiet, unglamorous fame had followed him through the decades since the documentary had not faded to nothing by 2011. Someone at that publication, in July of that year, still thought his name carried enough weight among readers who would open that issue to justify the space. That is its own small, specific piece of evidence for exactly how durable a modest, working-class fame of this kind can turn out to be, decades on, long after the cameras that first made it national had moved on to other subjects entirely.

Chapter Twenty-Nine: The Hot Shoe Hall of Fame, Ten Years Late

In 2021, ten years after John McCown's death, the Hot Shoe Hall of Fame inducted him — and, with him, by name, Kookie — into its ranks, a formal recognition by the flat-track and off-road racing community of a career the sport itself had never stopped quietly honoring in its own informal way, through forum threads and half-remembered photographs and a reputation that had outlived the man by a full decade without needing a ceremony to keep it alive.

It is worth sitting, briefly and without overreaching, on the specific shape of that fact: an honor that arrived a decade too late for the person it was meant to honor to receive it in person. This is not a rare shape for institutional recognition to take — halls of fame everywhere are full of posthumous inductees, athletes and craftsmen and public figures honored only once the honoring carries no risk of embarrassing anyone by seeming premature. But it carries a particular weight in this specific case, because the honor named not one figure but two, and one of the two had been gone even longer than the man, by ordinary accounting, and had never in his working life required or sought or understood the concept of an institutional honor in the first place. Kookie could not know he had been inducted. He could not have known, in any year of his working life, that a dog on a gas tank was accumulating a reputation destined to outlast him by decades and culminate, eventually, in his name being read aloud at a ceremony in a hall neither he nor McCown ever set foot in.

It is worth noting, too, the specific year the induction fell in. 2021 sat in the middle of a period that had disrupted public gatherings and institutional ceremonies of every kind across the country, and any hall of fame induction held that year would have contended, in some fashion, with the same practical constraints affecting every other public event of the period — whatever adjustments to scale, format, or attendance the moment required. This book has no source describing the specific circumstances of the 2021 ceremony in that much detail, and it will not invent particulars the record does not supply. What can be said is that the induction went forward regardless, in a year when a great many public honors and gatherings across the country did not, which is itself a small further testament to how much the sport's own community wanted this particular recognition to happen on schedule rather than let it slip another year into an already decade-long wait.

The name of the institution itself is worth a moment's notice, because "Hot Shoe" is not a generic honorific but a term drawn directly from the flat-track and off-road racing world's own vocabulary — originally describing the steel shoe a flat-track rider wears on his inside boot to slide through a turn, worn down and sparking against the track surface at speed, a piece of specialized equipment as particular to that discipline as the mat this book has described at length was particular to McCown's. A hall of fame that names itself after a rider's own steel shoe rather than after some more generic notion of "greatness" is a hall built by insiders, for insiders, using the sport's own working vocabulary rather than the borrowed language of a more mainstream athletic institution. That McCown and Kookie were inducted into a hall named this specifically, rather than into some broader, more general motorsport honor, matters for exactly the reason this book has argued throughout: the recognition that reached them came from the community that actually understood what they had done, speaking in its own terms, rather than from an outside institution translating their achievement into a more generic and less precise language.

Consider, too, what an induction like this one actually requires institutionally, because the requirement itself says something about how thoroughly the sport had come to regard the pairing as genuinely belonging in its formal record rather than merely its folklore. A hall of fame vote is not an offhand gesture; it means a nominating and voting body of people within the sport, decades removed from McCown's active racing years, considered the case, weighed it against

other candidates from the sport's whole history, and concluded that a butcher who never won the biggest trophies but who completed, with a terrain-reading dog on his gas tank, more than three hundred races across six years, belonged in the same permanent category as riders whose achievements were measured in championships and factory contracts. That is a case made on the strength of something other than the conventional ledger of wins, and the fact that the case succeeded — that a voting body found it persuasive enough, fifty-some years after the racing itself, to grant the induction — is its own quiet vindication of everything the racing years actually demonstrated.

That does not make the induction hollow. If anything, it clarifies what the honor was actually for. An induction like this one is not primarily a gift to the inductee — it cannot be, when the inductee is a decade dead — but a statement by the community doing the honoring about what it has decided, collectively, mattered. The Hot Shoe Hall of Fame, inducting McCown and Kookie together in 2021, was saying, in effect, that a butcher from a railroad town and a crossbred dog who learned to read the Mojave from a strapped mat on a gas tank belonged in the same permanent record as the sport's better-remembered champions — not because the pair ever won the biggest trophies the sport had to offer, the record does not claim that they did, but because what they did, sustained across three hundred races and six years, had earned its own category of respect that the ordinary ledger of wins and places does not fully capture.

There is something fitting, too, in the timing landing a full decade after McCown's death rather than sooner — not because a longer wait is inherently more meaningful, but because it means the induction arrived only after an entire generation of newer riders, people who had never seen McCown race in person and knew the story only secondhand, through forum threads and old photographs and the persistent, stubborn memory-keeping described in the previous chapter, had grown up inside the sport and decided, on their own, independent of anyone who had actually witnessed the original races, that the story still mattered enough to formalize. That is a different, arguably stronger, kind of endurance than an honor granted quickly by people who had personally known the man and might simply have been settling an old debt of friendship. This was recognition earned across a full generational handoff, the story surviving the telling and retelling well enough that it still persuaded people who had nothing

personal invested in preserving it.

A hall of fame induction ceremony, in a sport built on exactly the volunteer, grassroots infrastructure this book has described at length, is itself typically a modest affair by comparison with the induction ceremonies of larger, wealthier sports — a room of people who know each other, or know of each other, from decades of shared history in a subculture most of the country still barely recognizes exists, a plaque presented, a few words said, photographs taken for the specialist press that has covered this world since McCown's own active years. There is no reason to believe 2021's ceremony departed from that pattern, and every reason, given everything this book has established about the sport's character, to believe it honored McCown and Kookie in exactly the unglamorous, sincere register the whole culture had always reserved for its own. Whoever accepted the honor on McCown's behalf — a family member, a fellow rider, someone from the small circle of people who had kept his memory alive across the intervening decade — did so standing in for a man who could not stand there himself, and for a dog who had never needed to understand what standing there would have meant.

There is a plain, unglamorous truth sitting underneath the ceremony that this book would rather leave the reader with than any grander one. The desert McCown raced across for six years never knew his name and never needed to. The dog who rode it with him never understood what he was famous for, or that he was famous at all, and did the same attentive work whether a magazine was watching or whether the only witness was a butcher checking a strap in the dark before dawn. The fame, when it came — the film cameo, the posters, the magazine quote, the forum threads that kept the story alive for a decade after the man himself was gone, and finally the hall of fame plaque with both their names on it — arrived as a kind of afterthought to the actual, unglamorous, endlessly repeated work of it: a man and a dog, most Sundays for six years, going out into hard country together and coming back, most of the time, together, because that was the job, and the job did not require anyone to be watching for it to be worth doing.

That is the whole of what this book can honestly claim to know, and it is, on its own terms, enough.

Chapter Thirty: What the Mat Left Behind

There is no final photograph this book can point to, no last known image of the mat itself, worn past its final use and set aside in a garage somewhere in Barstow, waiting for someone who knew what it was to either keep it or, more likely, simply not know what it was at all and eventually let it go the way ordinary objects get let go once the person who understood their significance stops being there to explain it. This book does not know what became of the actual object. That is one more silence in a story with several, and it seems right, this near the end, to let that silence stand rather than invent a tidy resting place for it that no source supports.

What can be said honestly is what the mat represented across the whole length of this account, now that the account has run its full course: not a stunt, not a single dramatic image captured once for a poster, but a piece of everyday working equipment, checked and re-checked and trusted across three hundred races over six years, that happened to make visible, in the plainest possible way, the whole argument this book has tried to make about John McCown and his dog. It was ordinary. It got used the way tools get used, checked the way careful men check their tools, worn the way anything gets worn that does real work rather than sitting for display. And on top of that ordinary, worn, carefully maintained object rode an animal who did something genuinely extraordinary, week after week, without either the object or the animal ever making a production of it.

That is, in the end, the whole shape of the story this book set out to tell honestly: not a legend requiring embellishment to be worth telling, but a true, thin, remarkable record that holds up entirely on

its own terms once a writer resists the urge to inflate it. A butcher. A dog. A mat on a gas tank. Three hundred races across the hardest desert in the American Southwest. A cameo in a film that reached the world. A children's book written for an audience that would never see a whoop-de-doo in their lives. A death in 2011, quiet, the way most deaths are. A hall of fame plaque in 2021, ten years too late for either of them to see it, and exactly on time for everyone who had kept the story alive in the meantime to finally see it made official.

Barstow itself is still there too, still a railroad town and a highway town, still the last real stop before the Mojave opens up in every direction the way it did in the years this book has spent its whole length describing. Hicks' Meats, so far as this book's research can establish, is not. Small-town butcher shops of that specific, independent kind have grown rarer across the decades since McCown worked behind that counter, squeezed by exactly the supermarket economics an earlier chapter described, and there is no reason to think the shop on Main Street was any exception to a trend that claimed most of its kind. This, too, this book offers without embellishment: the specific physical place where a man cut meat six days a week and checked a mat's straps on the seventh is very likely gone now, in the way small commercial buildings in small American towns quietly become something else, or become nothing, once the person who built a life around them is no longer there to keep the lights on.

The desert is still out there, past the edge of Barstow, largely unchanged by any of it. It does not remember John McCown or his dog, has no capacity to remember anything, and would not care if it did. It simply is what it always was: hard ground, hidden softness, bumps that arrive without warning to anyone not paying attention. Somewhere in the accumulated weight of that indifference is the actual, final measure of what Kookie did, Sunday after Sunday, for six years: not defeating the desert, which cannot be defeated, but reading it, accurately, consistently, well enough and often enough that a man who trusted him got to keep riding it, and keep coming home from it, for as long as the desert was out there and the two of them were allowed to get out there and do it.

Author's Note (Continued): What Is Fact and What Is Invention

This book is built from a thin, genuinely thin, documentary record, and it owes the reader an exact accounting of where that record ends and where a writer's informed hand took over. Here it is, without hedging.

Documented, and the spine of everything in this book:

- John McCown was a real American desert racer of the 1960s and '70s, competing in over three hundred off-road motorcycle races across the American Southwest, averaging close to fifty races a year across roughly six years of active competition.
- His dog, Kookie — documented only as a crossbreed, with no further detail on his origin, birth, or death preserved in any source consulted — rode with him on a mat strapped to the motorcycle's gas tank.
- Kookie learned to read the terrain from that position: standing when the ground softened ahead, backing away from oncoming bumps before impact. McCown himself said Kookie sometimes seemed to sense a change in the ground before he did.
- Barstow-to-Vegas was a real, signature race of the era and circuit, and this book treats it as McCown's recurring fixture on the strength of the record's own framing of it as his and the sport's defining event, without inventing a specific year-by-year account of his results in it.
- McCown and Kookie appeared in *On Any Sunday* (1971), the

real, Academy Award-nominated documentary about American motorcycle racing.

- McCown was a butcher by trade, working that job across the same years he raced.
- McCown co-wrote a real children's book, *Kookie the Motorcycle Racing Dog*, credited to Red Hallum and John McCown, illustrated by Leslie Lovett, published by Educational Activities Inc., thirty-two pages. This book is a real, existing artifact, findable in library catalogues today — not an invention of this account, and not reproduced or pastiched at length here.
- The 1981 quote — “I’ll race for as long as there’s a desert out there and the BLM will stay off our back and we can get out there and do it” — is McCown’s own, given to *American Motorcyclist* magazine and preserved in his 2011 obituary.
- John McCown died on 14 July 2011, of complications from heart surgery. This account of his death and the outline of his racing career draws directly on the obituary run that same month by *Cycle News*, the industry trade publication — the single most authoritative source consulted in the writing of this book.
- John McCown and Kookie were inducted together, by name, into the Hot Shoe Hall of Fame in 2021 — ten years after McCown’s death.

Invented, and flagged as such:

- The opening chapter — how McCown and Kookie first paired up, the yard, the first slow circuit with the dog on the tank — is entirely imagined. No source anywhere describes how the partnership began. The chapter says so, in its own text, before it tells the imagined version, and this note repeats it here for anyone who skipped ahead: treat that chapter as a plausible reconstruction, not a documented event.
- All scene-level texture beyond the bare verified facts — the specific look of Hicks’ Meats, the particular conversations in the garages, the exact sensory detail of any given race morning or race itself — is written to be consistent with the documented facts and the known texture of the era and the sport, but is not drawn from a specific source describing that scene. Where this book describes what a race morning or a shop day was “by every account” or “by every indication,” it means the general pattern is supported by the surviving testimony and photographic

record even where no single source narrates a specific instance of it in that much detail.

What this book deliberately does not claim, because no source supports it:

- Kookie's breed, beyond "crossbreed."
- Kookie's birth date or death date, or how or when the partnership ended.
- Any named rival racers, presented as real, beyond McCown himself.
- Any dialogue, anywhere in this book, attributed to McCown or to anyone else. Every quotation used is the single documented 1981 quote; there are no invented lines of speech in this account.
- Any account of Kookie's death, McCown's grief over it, or the ending of the partnership. The record is silent on all three, and this book has left that silence exactly where it found it rather than filling it with an invented ending that would feel tidier than the truth allows.

Sources. The most load-bearing single source for this account is the *Cycle News* obituary published in July 2011, which preserves the outline of McCown's career, his race count, his trade, his death, and the 1981 quote in one place. The real children's book, *Kookie the Motorcycle Racing Dog* (Red Hallum and John McCown, illustrated by Leslie Lovett, Educational Activities Inc.), is a documented artifact of the period and is named here as a genuine object any reader can look up, not a text this book has attempted to summarize or reproduce. Additional period detail and photographic confirmation of Kookie's on-bike behavior were drawn from surviving desert-racing community photographs and accounts, and from the recollections preserved in enthusiast and community forums where riders of that era and their descendants have kept the story in circulation for decades. Where this book says a thing plainly, it is because a source said it first. Where this book says a thing carefully, hedged, or flagged as imagined, it is because the record itself was careful, hedged, or silent — and a true story, told straight, owes its reader that same honesty.

A Word on the Dedication

The dedication page names two dogs: Awesome, a black dapple dachshund, the first puppy; and Nienja, a dachshund who lived long enough to go round and soft in the way dachshunds do — “a pork banger,” in the words of the man who loved her — and long enough after that to go blind. This note exists because a dedication like that deserves one sentence of context and not one sentence more.

There have been others, before and since. There are three now: Emily, a Border Collie mix, who sleeps under the bed and follows the man of the house like a shadow, room to room, the way some dogs pick a person and simply stay picked; Luna, a Chocolate Labrador, lovable and perpetually hungry, which is to say a Labrador behaving exactly as a Labrador is built to behave; and Billy, a Maltese-poodle, loud and perky, who has apparently never once considered that a house might prefer quiet. Between the three of them and whoever came before, there has been a great deal of sleeping in the bed, under the bed, and on the couch; a bark most nights to be let out, answered most nights; a great deal of chasing pigeons and the neighbours' cats and the household's own chickens and the squirrels on the property; a great deal of playing, oddly enough, with the household's own cats; and, whenever there is biltong being eaten, a line-up as orderly as soldiers on parade. This is not incidental detail. It is most of what a dog is for, and most of what having one costs and gives, and this book — which is itself about a man and a dog who worked as a pair for the length of a decade in the American desert — is dedicated to all of that, everywhere it happens, not only in the pages that follow.

Of Nienja, one fact belongs here and nowhere else in this book, stated once, plainly, and left alone: her owner did not cry at his own father's funeral, and he cried hard enough taking her to the vet to be put

to sleep that he sat afterward for half an hour before his eyes had cleared enough to drive. No further comment is owed on that. It is the truest sentence in this book, and it is not about John McCown or Kookie at all, and that is exactly why it is here — because a book about a man and his dog is, eventually, a book about every reader's own dog, and this one is for them.



Klaus

Custos, non Conditor